Guitar Scales

6 Ways to Play Every Scale

Fretboard pictures, tabs, fingers and octave markers for every way, for class and stage.

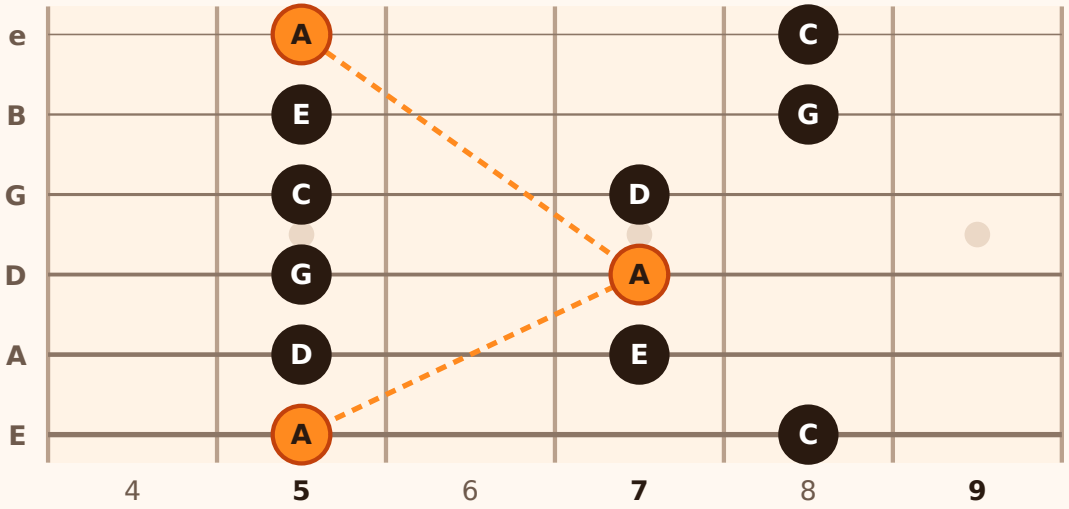
Inside

- How to read this book
- Finding the octaves
- A Major Scale
- A Natural Minor Scale
- A Major Pentatonic
- A Minor Pentatonic
- A Blues Scale
- Play in any key

Barney Musicals · Shine Worshippers Academy

How to read this book

Every scale page has a fretboard picture, a tab to play up, and a tab to play down



The picture

The neck is drawn as you see it when you look down at your guitar: the thin 1st string (e) is on top, the thick 6th string (E) is at the bottom. This matches the tab.

The dots

Each dot is a note to play. The letter inside is the note name.

Orange dots

The home note (A). Start and finish here.

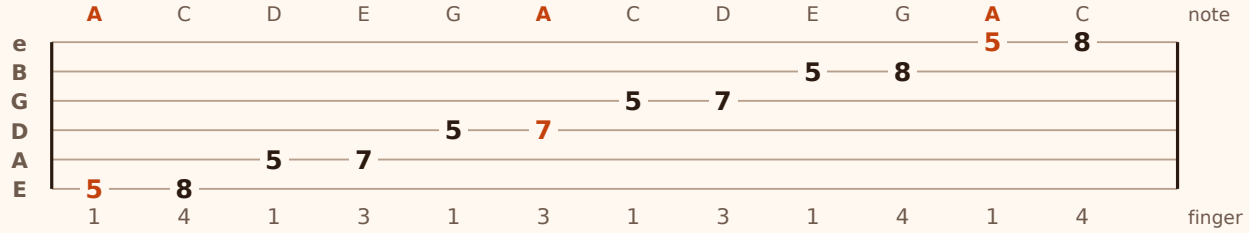
Dashed lines

Join an A to the next A, one octave higher.

Blue dots

Only in the blues scale: the “blue note” E♭.

Reading the tab



Tab lines

Six lines = six strings, high e on top. The number tells you which fret to press.

Note row

Above the tab: the name of each note. Sing or say it while you play.

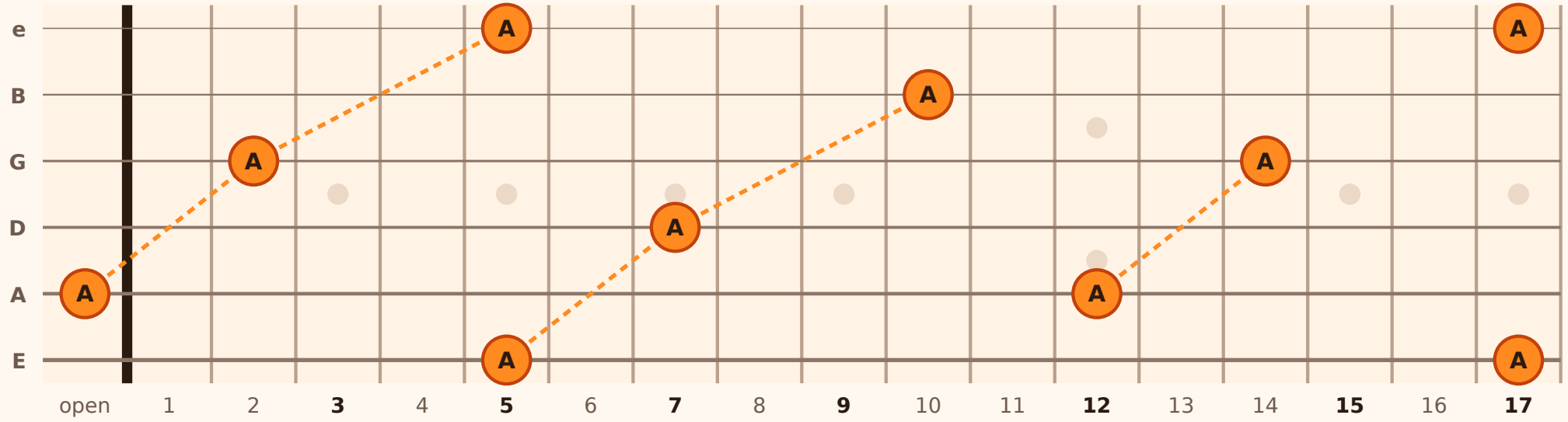
Finger row

Below the tab: 1 = index, 2 = middle, 3 = ring, 4 = little finger.

Tip for class or stage: open this book full screen and use one page per way. Every page stands on its own.

Finding the octaves

Know where every A is, and you can never get lost on the neck



Octave shapes (each one goes up one octave)

6th string → 4th string
skip one string, go up 2 frets (A: fret 5 → fret 7)

5th string → 3rd string
skip one string, go up 2 frets (A: fret 12 → fret 14)

4th string → 2nd string
skip one string, go up 3 frets (A: fret 7 → fret 10)

3rd string → 1st string
skip one string, go up 3 frets (A: fret 2 → fret 5)

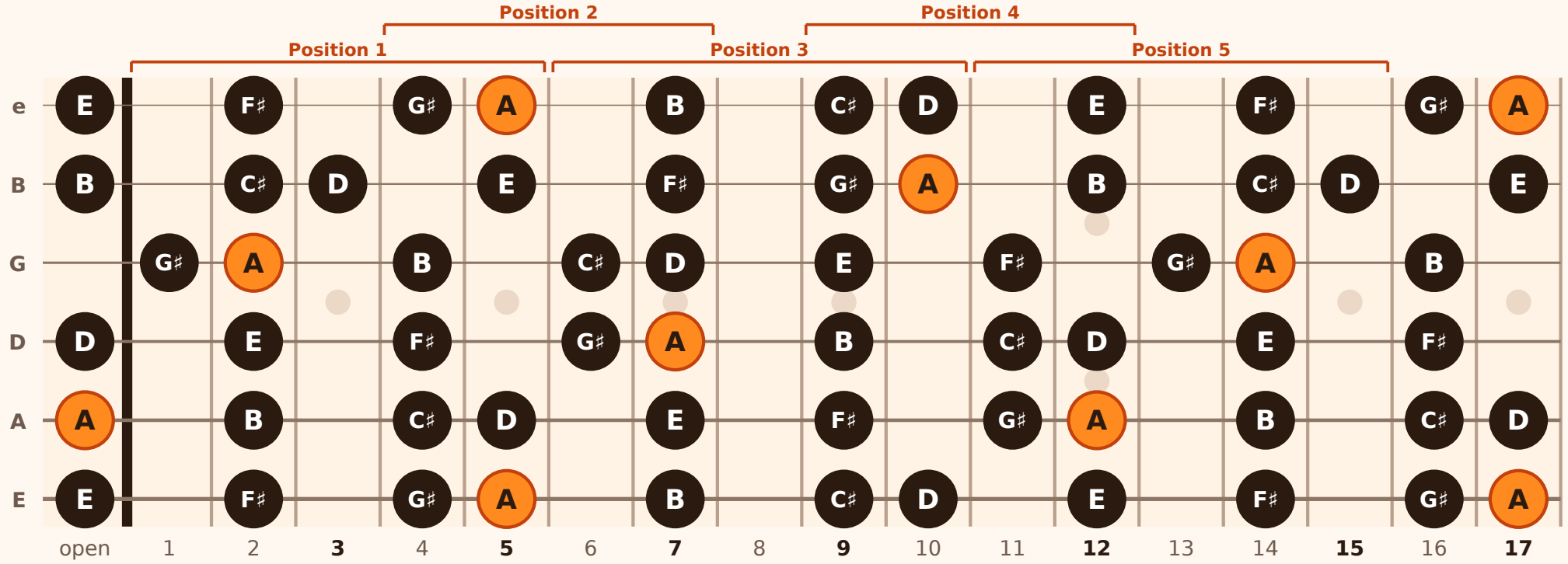
6th string → 1st string
same fret, two octaves higher (A: fret 5 → fret 5)

Same string
go up 12 frets (A: fret 5 → fret 17)

Why +3 frets on the 2nd string? The B string is tuned one fret lower than the others, so shapes that cross it move up one fret.

A Major Scale

Six ways to play it · The happy, bright sound of “Do Re Mi”. Used in most worship songs and melodies.



The whole neck

Every dot above is a note of the scale. Orange dots are A, the home note. The five positions sit side by side and overlap, so you can move from one to the next. Way 6 joins them in one long shape.

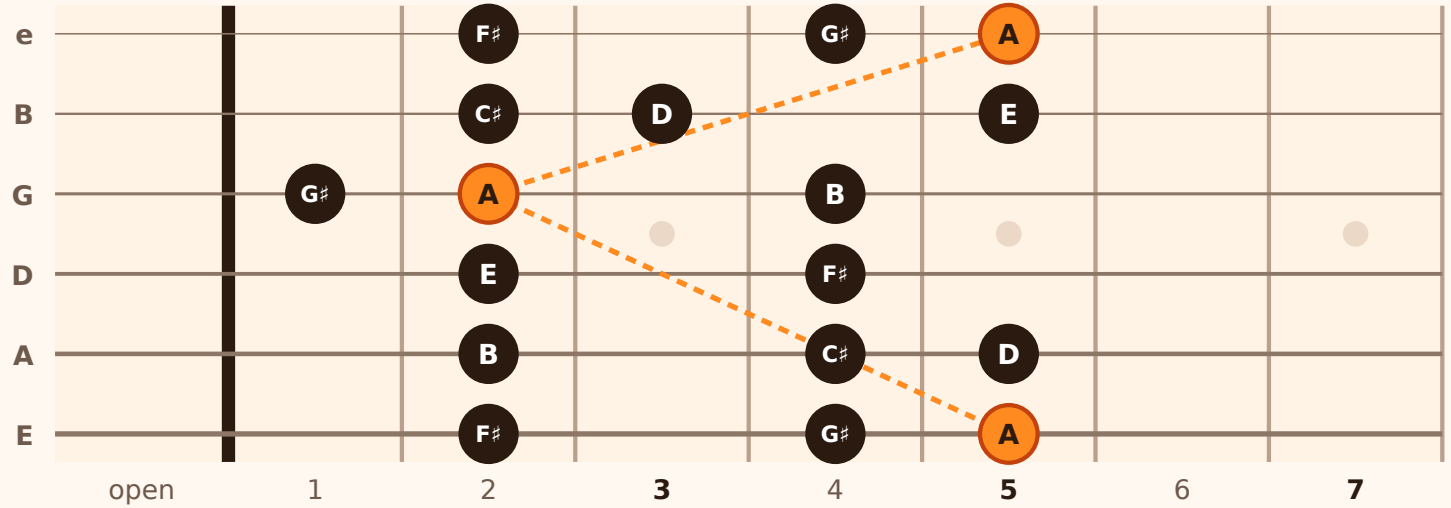
How to use these pages

1. Play over an A major chord, or songs in the key of A.
2. Learn one position a week. Play it up and down, slowly, saying the note names.
3. Find the orange A notes first: they are your map.
4. Then join two positions together on the neck.

Notes: A (1) B (2) C♯ (3) D (4) E (5) F♯ (6) G♯ (7)

A Major Scale — Way 1 · Position 1

Frets 1–5 · Put your 1st finger at fret 2



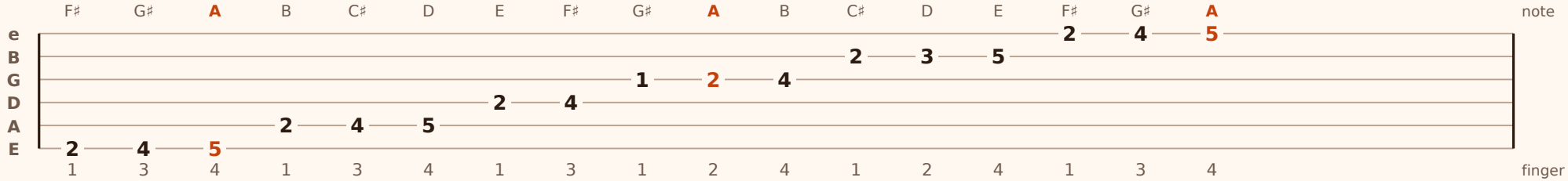
Octave reference

- **A 6th string, fret 5** — low A
- **A 3rd string, fret 2** — A · 1 octave up
- **A 1st string, fret 5** — A · 2 octaves up
- joins each A to the A an octave up

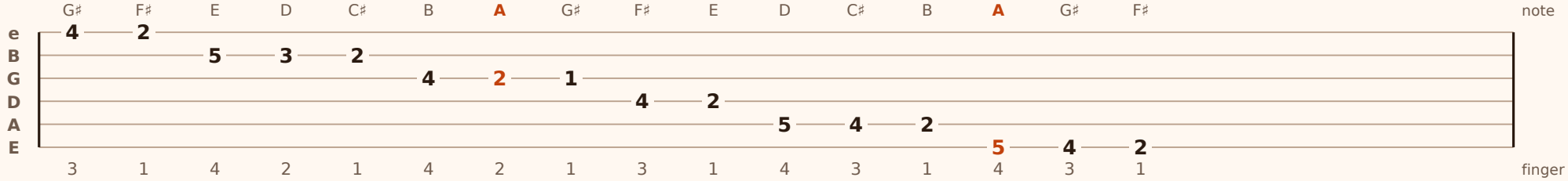
Notes in this scale

A	B	C♯	D	E	F♯	G♯
1	2	3	4	5	6	7

Play up (low to high)



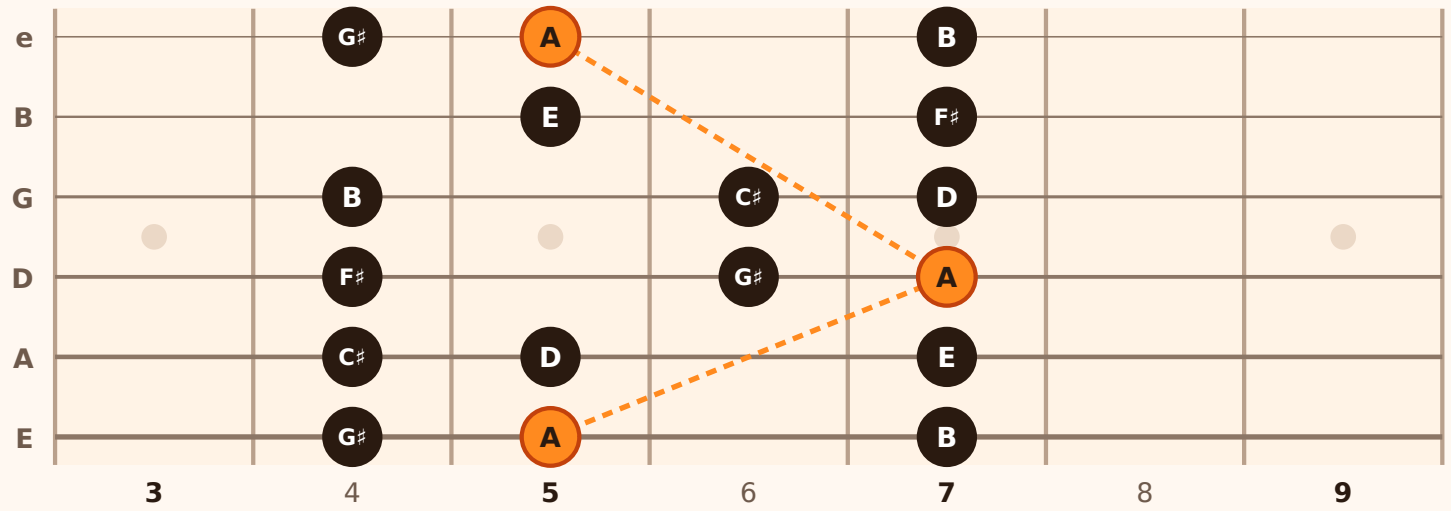
Play down (high to low)



Tip: Say the note names as you play. Start and finish on an orange A. Use a metronome at 60, then speed up.

A Major Scale — Way 2 · Position 2

Frets 4–7 · Put your 1st finger at fret 4



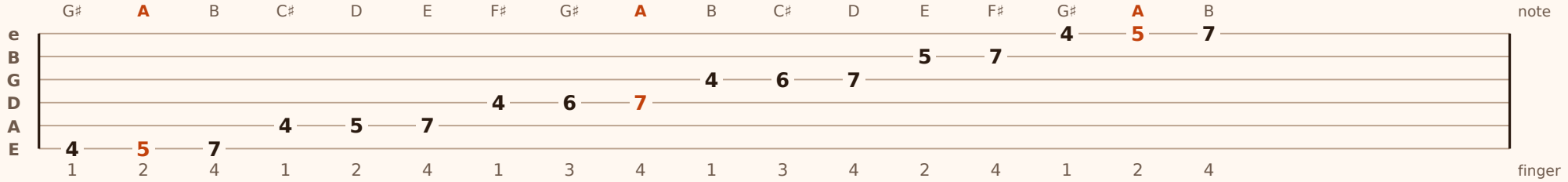
Octave reference

- **A** **6th string, fret 5** — low A
- **A** **4th string, fret 7** — A · 1 octave up
- **A** **1st string, fret 5** — A · 2 octaves up
- joins each A to the A an octave up

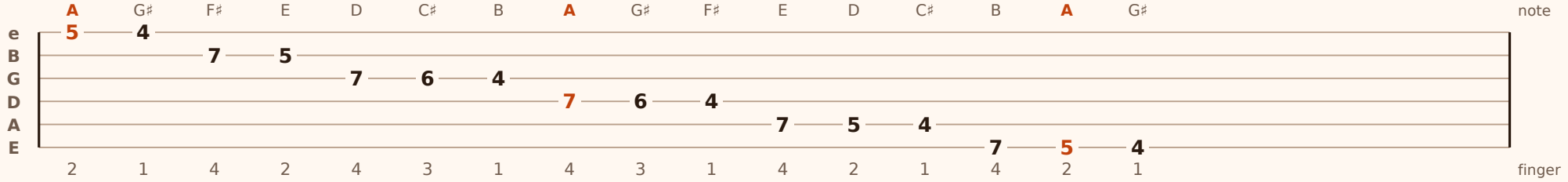
Notes in this scale

A	B	C♯	D	E	F♯	G♯
1	2	3	4	5	6	7

Play up (low to high)



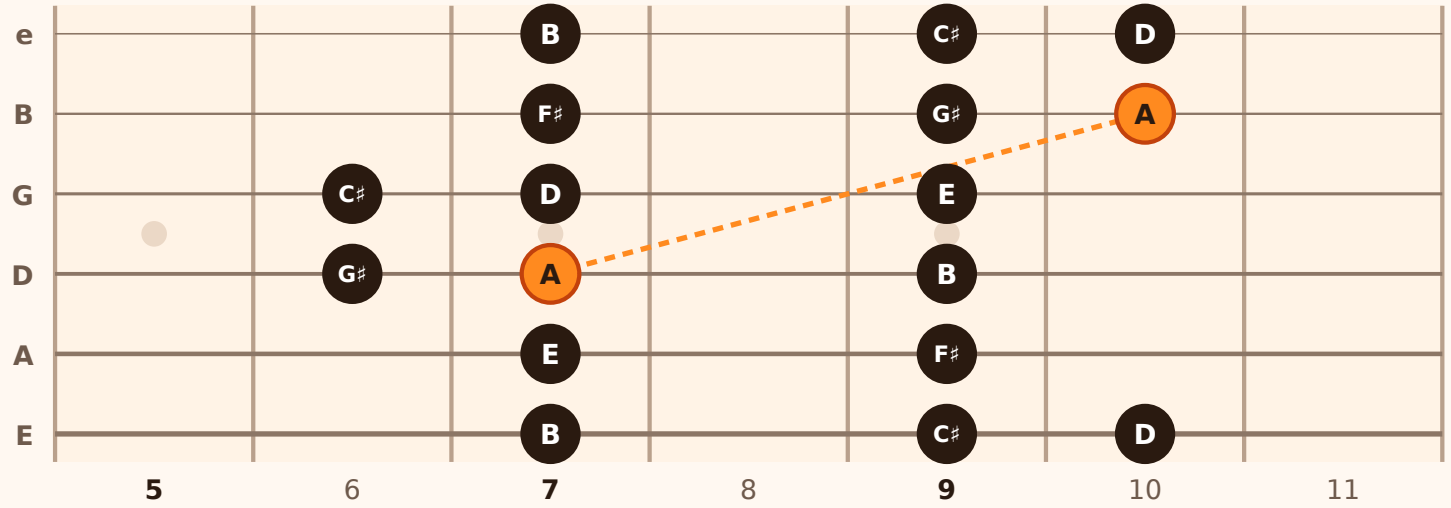
Play down (high to low)



Tip: Say the note names as you play. Start and finish on an orange A. Use a metronome at 60, then speed up.

A Major Scale — Way 3 · Position 3

Frets 6–10 · Put your 1st finger at fret 7



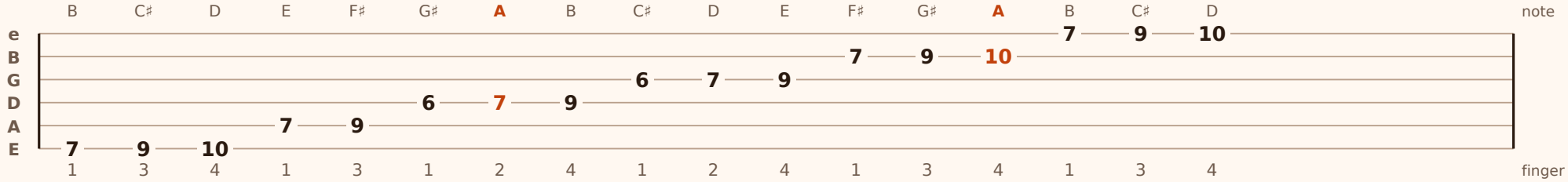
Octave reference

- **A** **4th string, fret 7** — A · 1 octave up
- **A** **2nd string, fret 10** — A · 2 octaves up
- joins each A to the A an octave up

Notes in this scale

A	B	C♯	D	E	F♯	G♯
1	2	3	4	5	6	7

Play up (low to high)



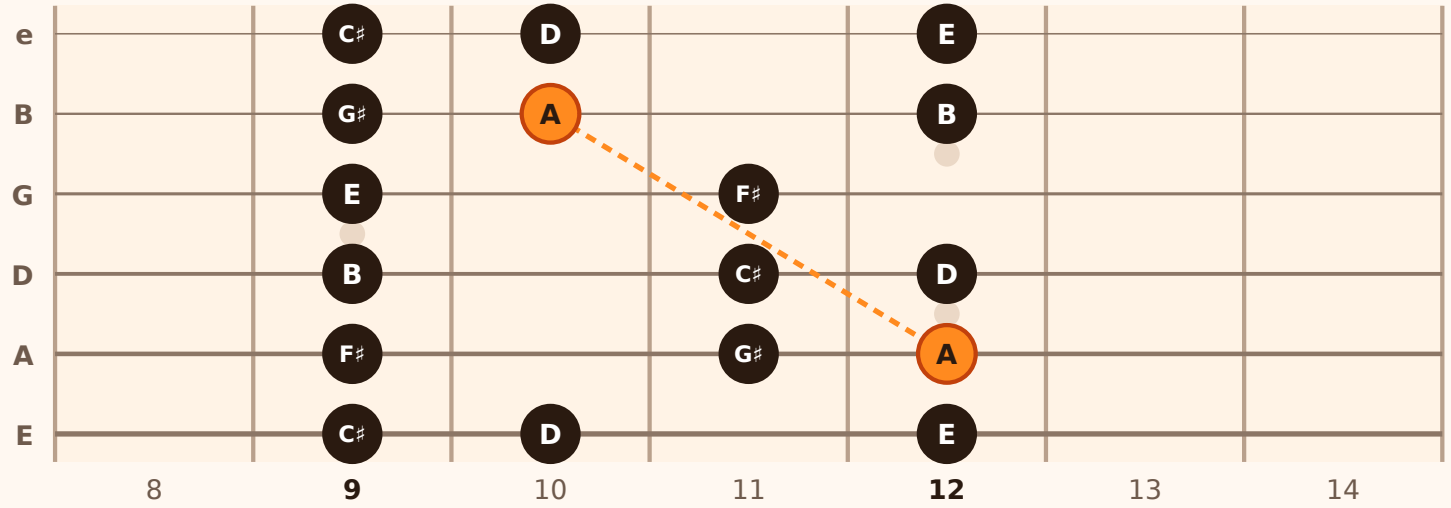
Play down (high to low)



Tip: Say the note names as you play. Start and finish on an orange A. Use a metronome at 60, then speed up.

A Major Scale — Way 4 · Position 4

Frets 9–12 · Put your 1st finger at fret 9



Octave reference

- **A** **5th string, fret 12**
  A · 1 octave up
- **A** **2nd string, fret 10**
  A · 2 octaves up
- joins each A to the A an octave up

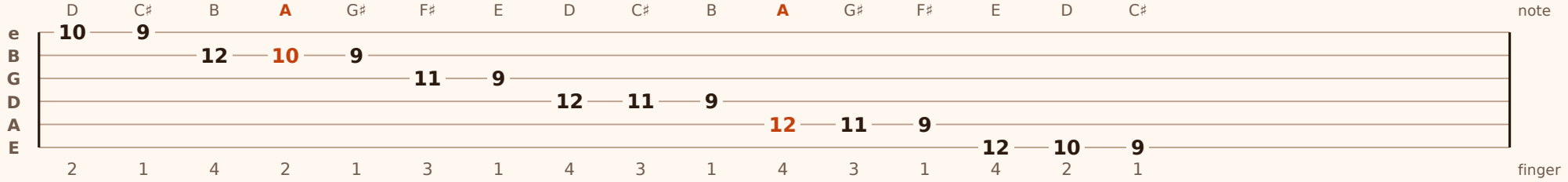
Notes in this scale

A	B	C♯	D	E	F♯	G♯
1	2	3	4	5	6	7

Play up (low to high)



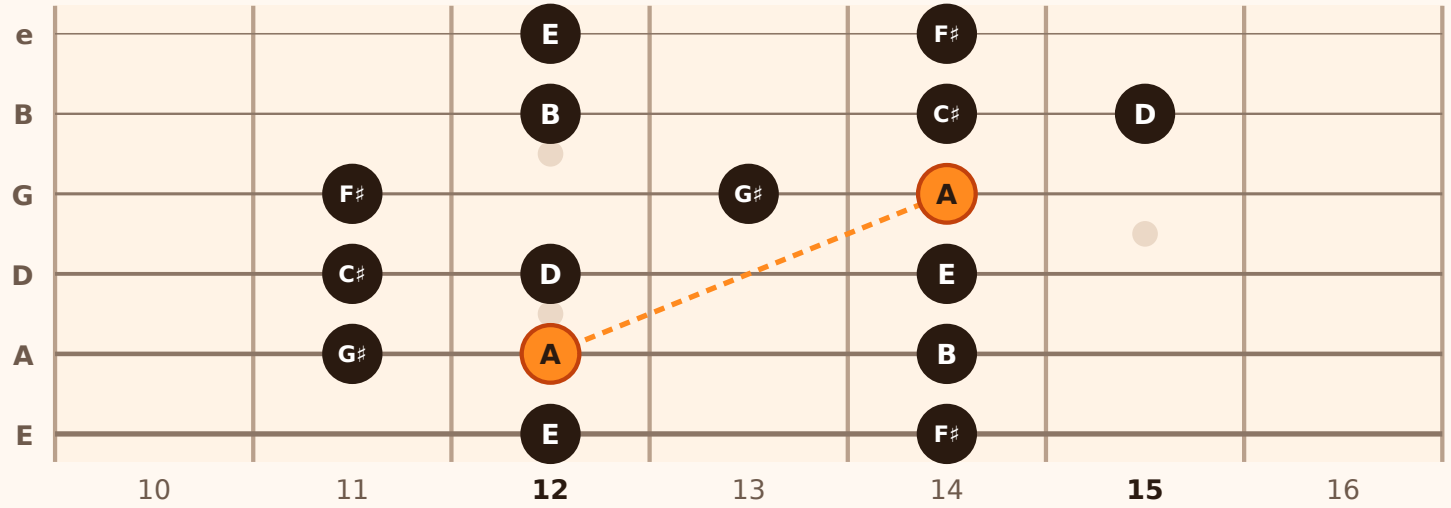
Play down (high to low)



Tip: Say the note names as you play. Start and finish on an orange A. Use a metronome at 60, then speed up.

A Major Scale — Way 5 · Position 5

Frets 11–15 · Put your 1st finger at fret 11



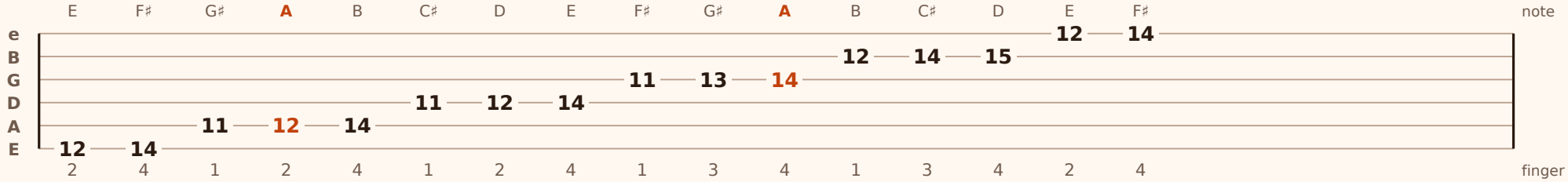
Octave reference

- **A** **5th string, fret 12**
  A · 1 octave up
- **A** **3rd string, fret 14**
  A · 2 octaves up
- joins each A to the A an octave up

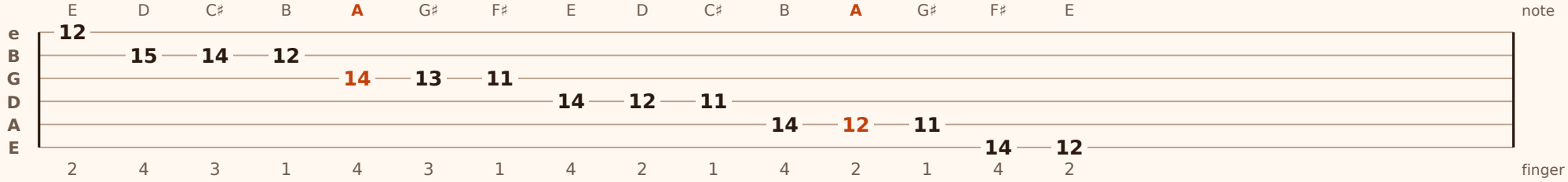
Notes in this scale

A	B	C♯	D	E	F♯	G♯
1	2	3	4	5	6	7

Play up (low to high)



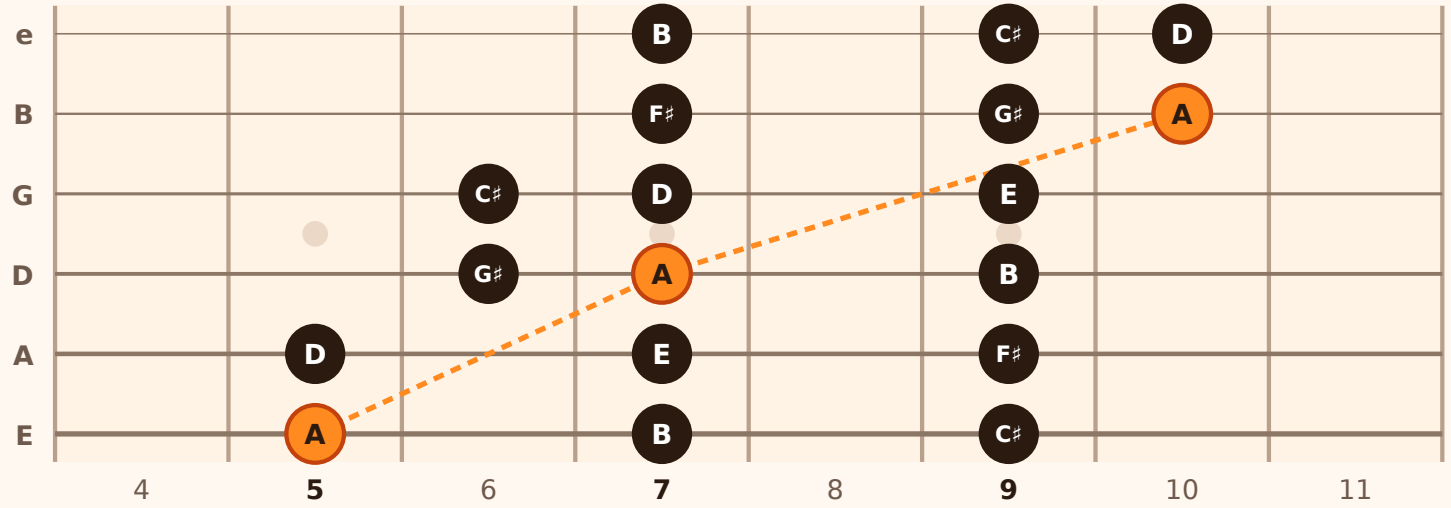
Play down (high to low)



Tip: Say the note names as you play. Start and finish on an orange A. Use a metronome at 60, then speed up.

A Major Scale — Way 6 · Three notes on every string

Frets 5–10 · Starts on low A (6th string, fret 5) · Smooth and fast for runs



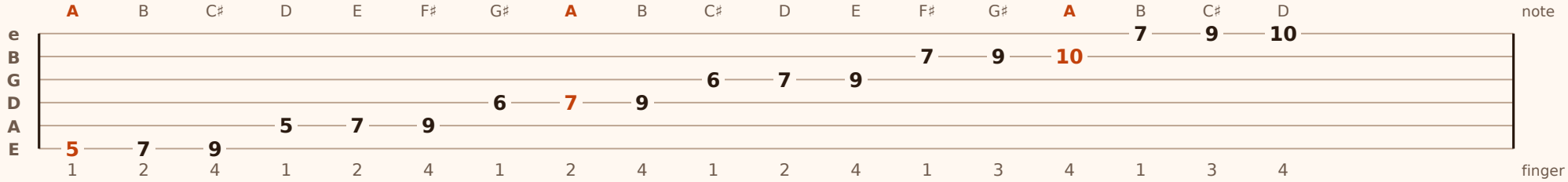
Octave reference

- **6th string, fret 5** — low A
- **4th string, fret 7** — A · 1 octave up
- **2nd string, fret 10** — A · 2 octaves up
- joins each A to the A an octave up

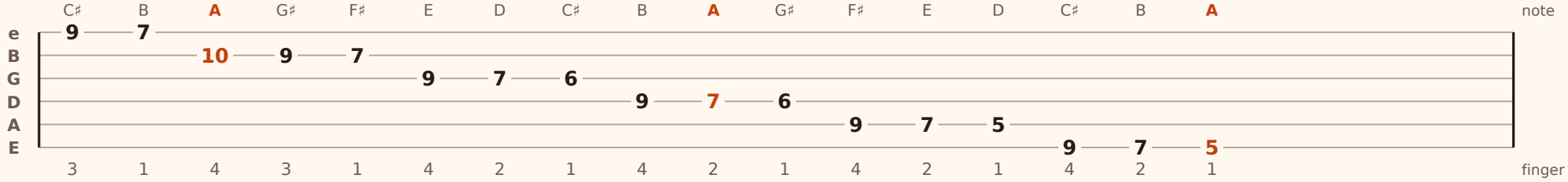
Notes in this scale

A	B	C♯	D	E	F♯	G♯
1	2	3	4	5	6	7

Play up (low to high)



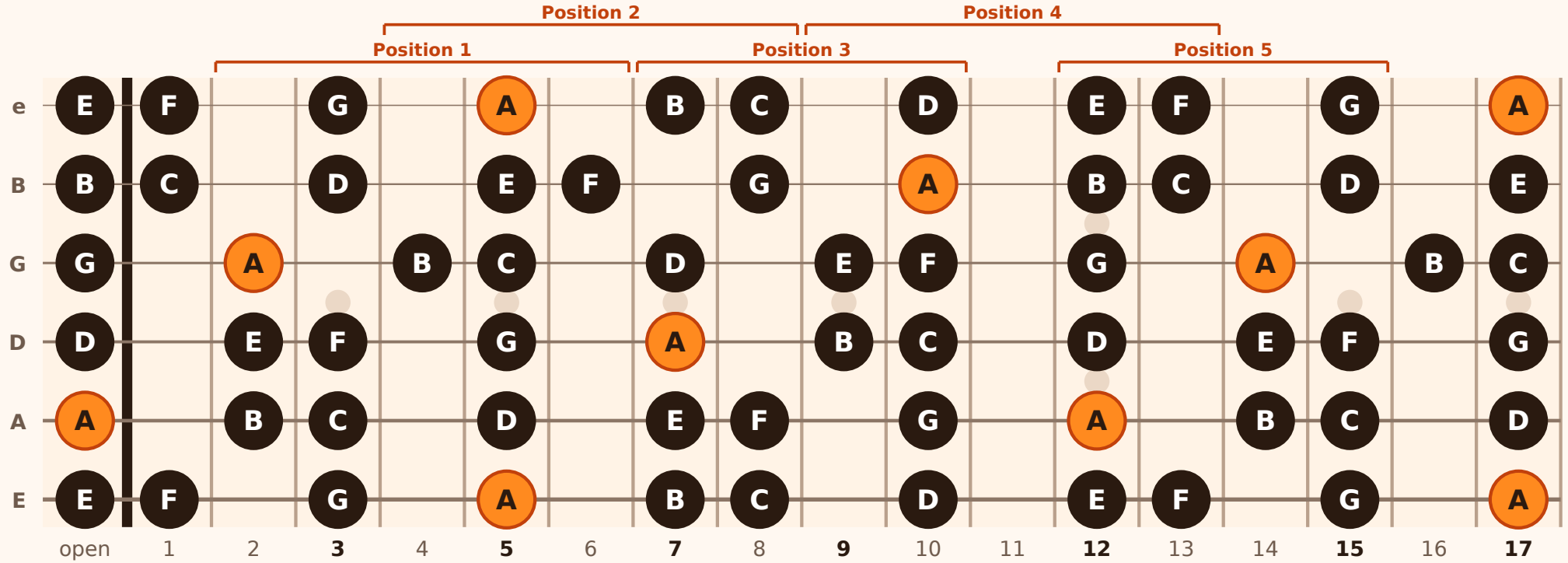
Play down (high to low)



Tip: Three notes on each string. Pick down-up-down evenly; this is the shape for fast runs.

A Natural Minor Scale

Six ways to play it · The sad, serious sound. Same notes as C major, but A is home.



The whole neck

Every dot above is a note of the scale. Orange dots are A, the home note. The five positions sit side by side and overlap, so you can move from one to the next. Way 6 joins them in one long shape.

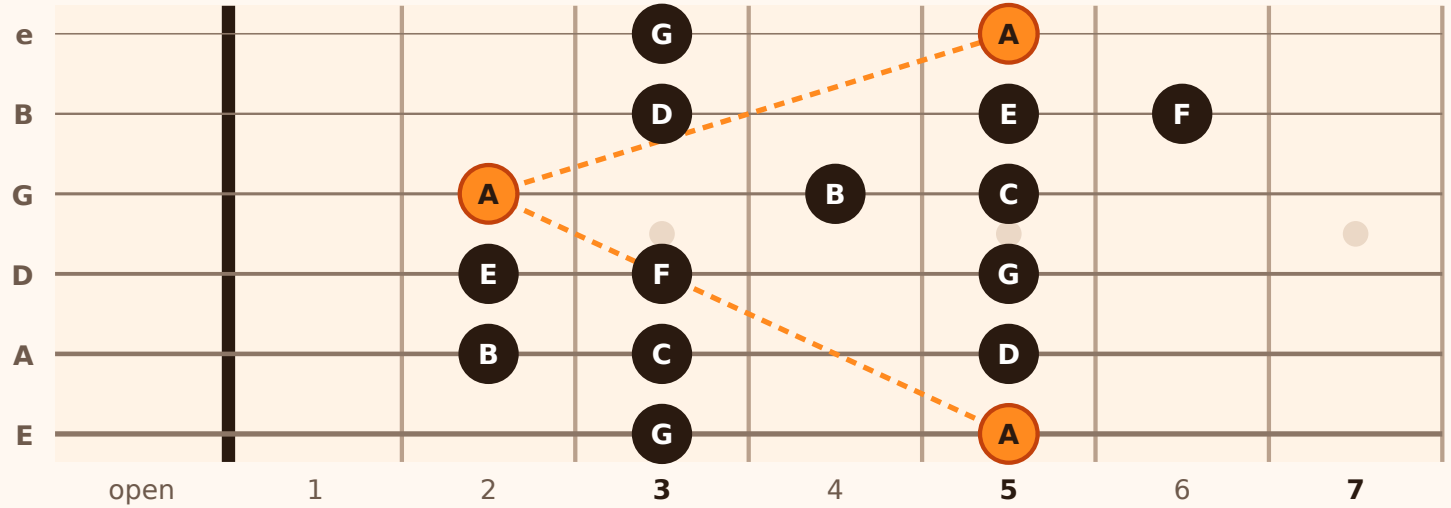
How to use these pages

1. Play over an A minor chord, or songs in A minor.
2. Learn one position a week. Play it up and down, slowly, saying the note names.
3. Find the orange A notes first: they are your map.
4. Then join two positions together on the neck.

Notes: A (1) B (2) C (♭3) D (4) E (5) F (♭6) G (♭7)

A Natural Minor Scale — Way 1 · Position 1

Frets 2–6 · Put your 1st finger at fret 2



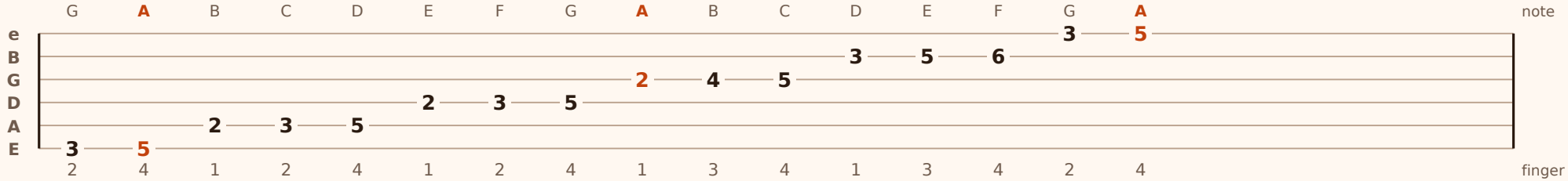
Octave reference

- **6th string, fret 5** — low A
- **3rd string, fret 2** — A · 1 octave up
- **1st string, fret 5** — A · 2 octaves up
- joins each A to the A an octave up

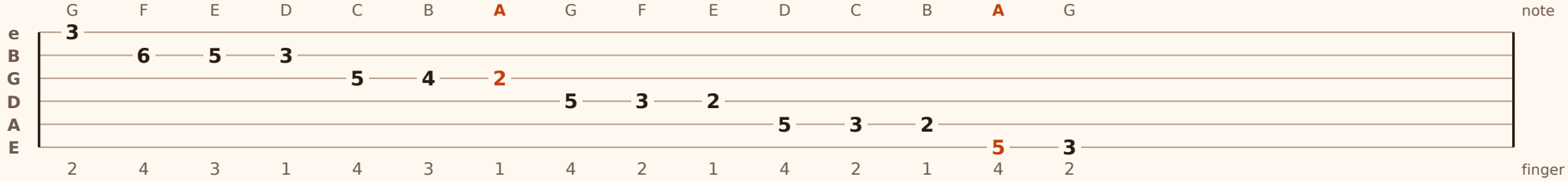
Notes in this scale

A	B	C	D	E	F	G
1	2	♭3	4	5	♭6	♭7

Play up (low to high)



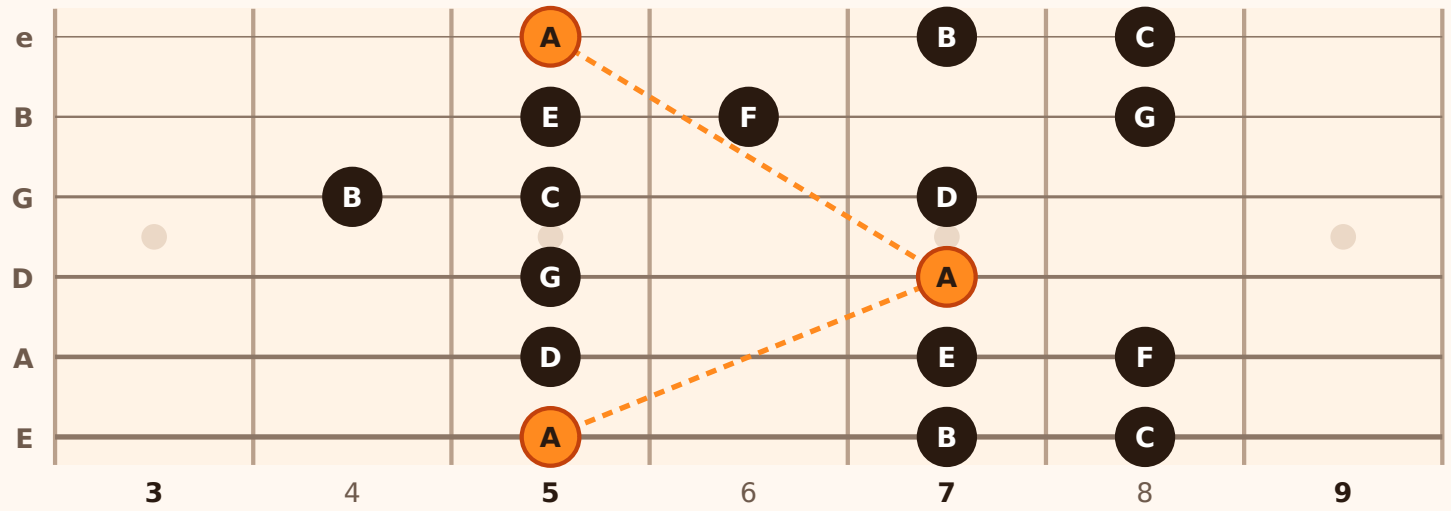
Play down (high to low)



Tip: Say the note names as you play. Start and finish on an orange A. Use a metronome at 60, then speed up.

A Natural Minor Scale — Way 2 · Position 2

Frets 4–8 · Put your 1st finger at fret 5



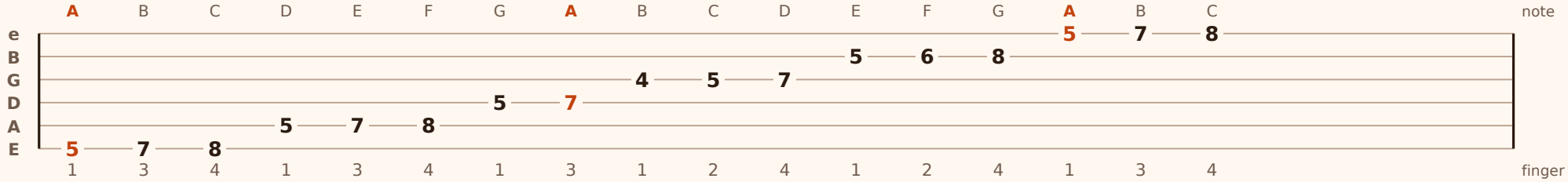
Octave reference

- **A 6th string, fret 5** — low A
- **A 4th string, fret 7** — A · 1 octave up
- **A 1st string, fret 5** — A · 2 octaves up
- joins each A to the A an octave up
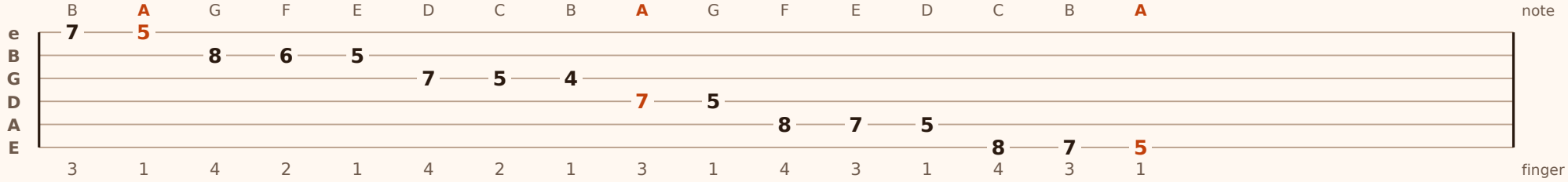
Notes in this scale

A	B	C	D	E	F	G
1	2	♭3	4	5	♭6	♭7

Play up (low to high)



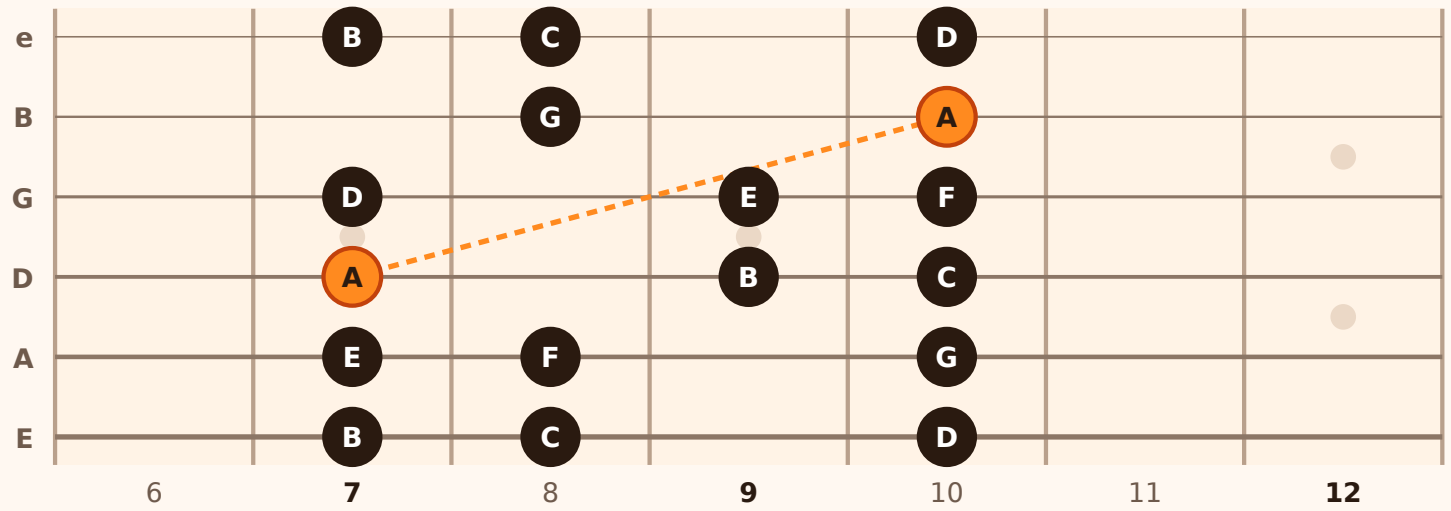
Play down (high to low)



Tip: Say the note names as you play. Start and finish on an orange A. Use a metronome at 60, then speed up.

A Natural Minor Scale — Way 3 · Position 3

Frets 7–10 · Put your 1st finger at fret 7



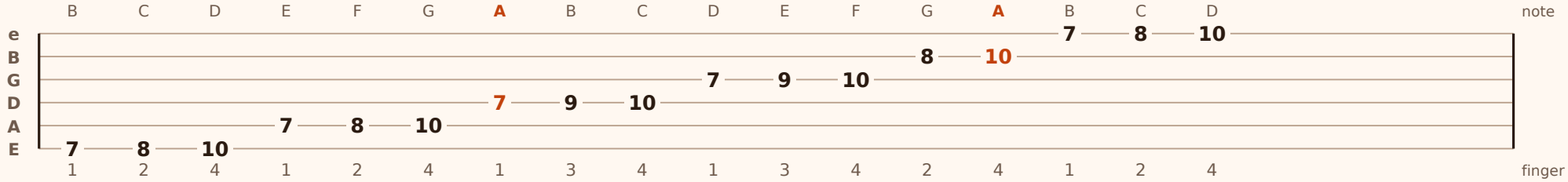
Octave reference

- **A** **4th string, fret 7** — A · 1 octave up
- **A** **2nd string, fret 10** — A · 2 octaves up
- joins each A to the A an octave up

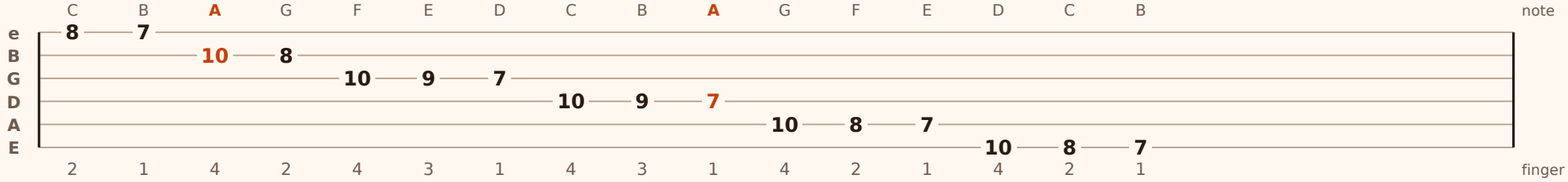
Notes in this scale

A	B	C	D	E	F	G
1	2	♭3	4	5	♭6	♭7

Play up (low to high)



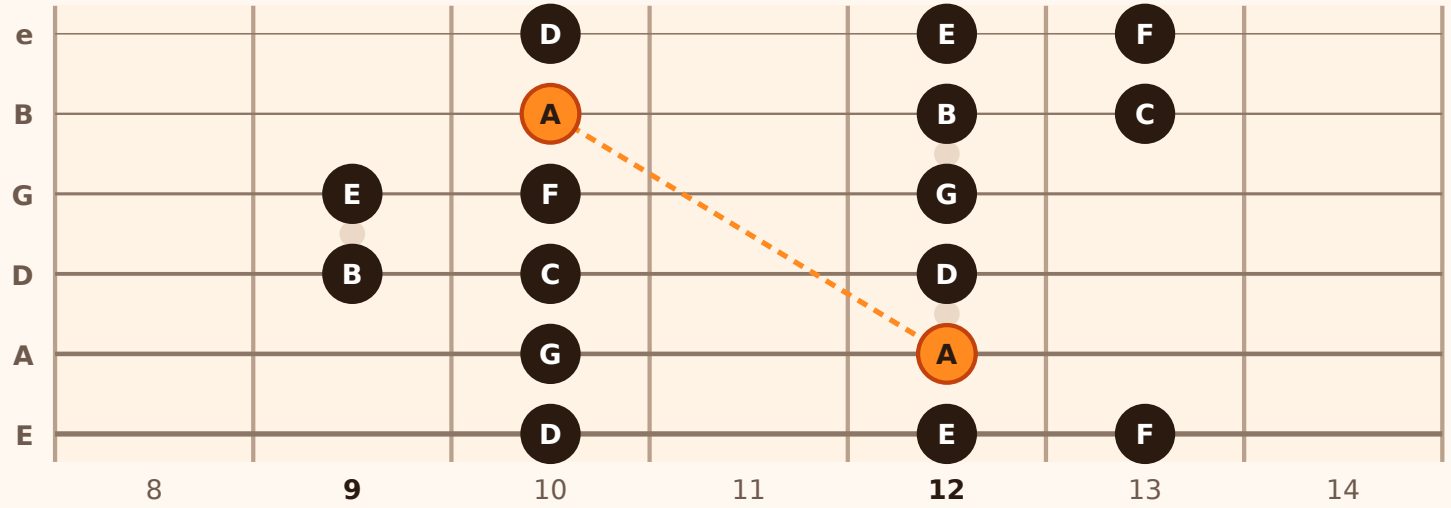
Play down (high to low)



Tip: Say the note names as you play. Start and finish on an orange A. Use a metronome at 60, then speed up.

A Natural Minor Scale — Way 4 · Position 4

Frets 9–13 · Put your 1st finger at fret 10



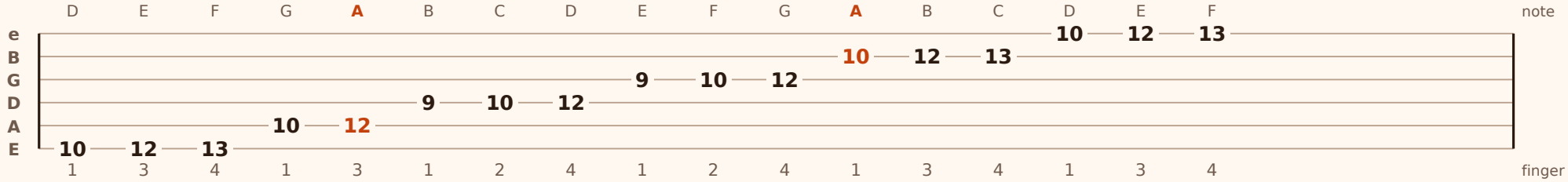
Octave reference

- **5th string, fret 12** — A · 1 octave up
- **2nd string, fret 10** — A · 2 octaves up
- joins each A to the A an octave up

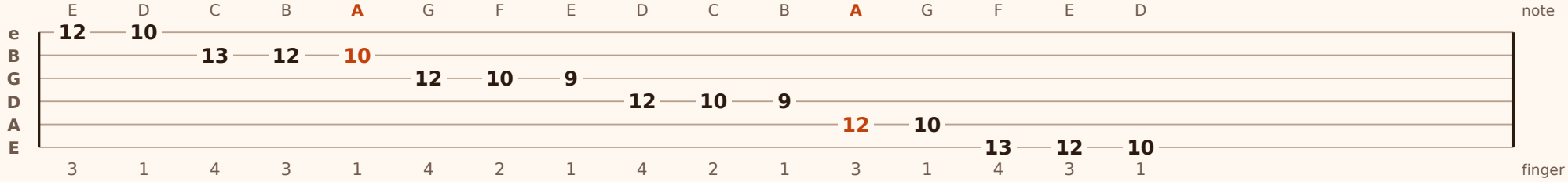
Notes in this scale

A	B	C	D	E	F	G
1	2	♭3	4	5	♭6	♭7

Play up (low to high)



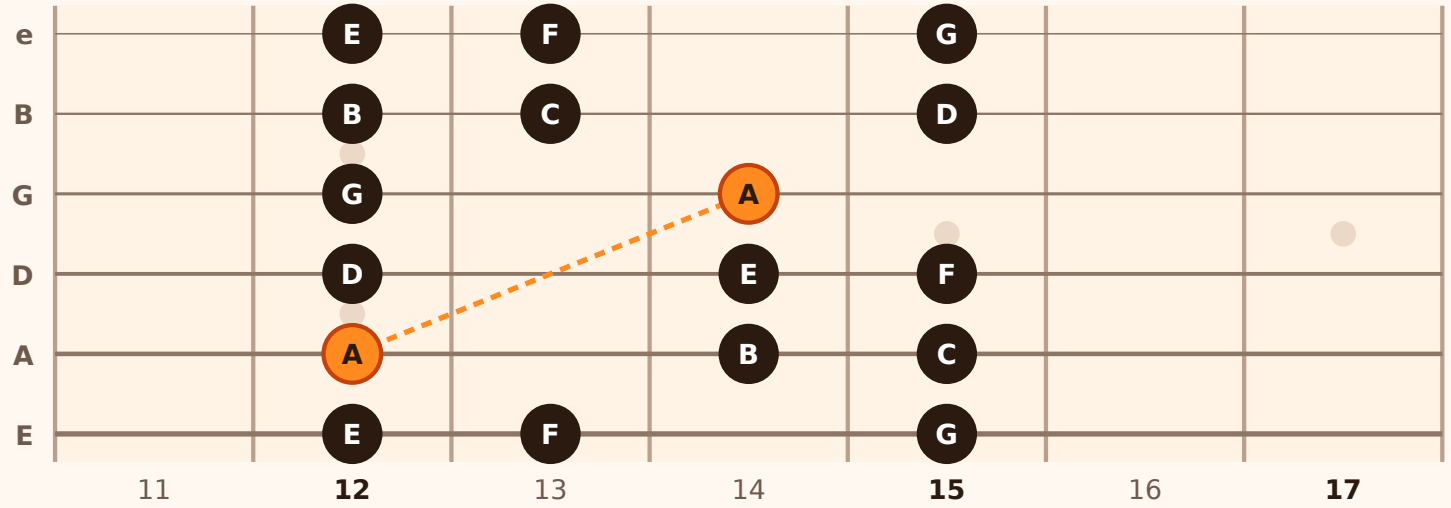
Play down (high to low)



Tip: Say the note names as you play. Start and finish on an orange A. Use a metronome at 60, then speed up.

A Natural Minor Scale — Way 5 · Position 5

Frets 12–15 · Put your 1st finger at fret 12



Octave reference

- **A** **5th string, fret 12**
  A · 1 octave up
- **A** **3rd string, fret 14**
  A · 2 octaves up
- joins each A to the A an octave up

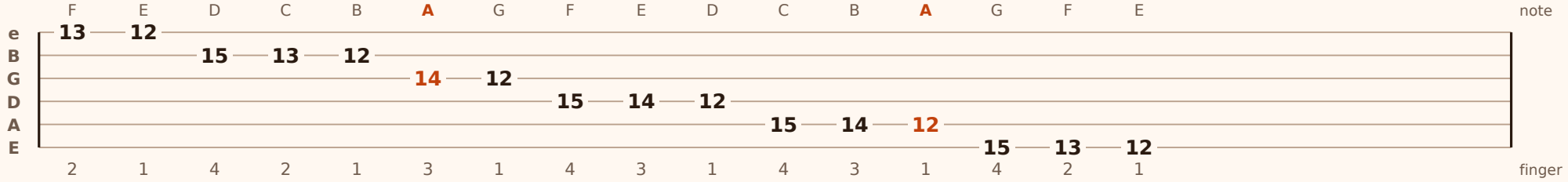
Notes in this scale

A	B	C	D	E	F	G
1	2	♭3	4	5	♭6	♭7

Play up (low to high)



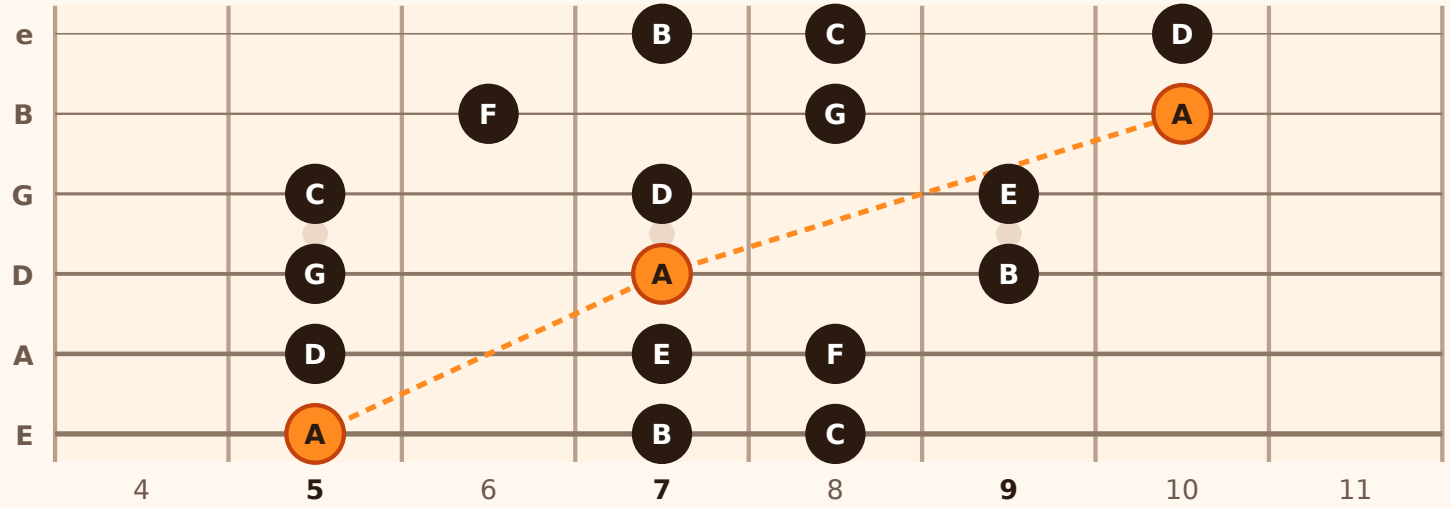
Play down (high to low)



Tip: Say the note names as you play. Start and finish on an orange A. Use a metronome at 60, then speed up.

A Natural Minor Scale — Way 6 · Three notes on every string

Frets 5–10 · Starts on low A (6th string, fret 5) · Smooth and fast for runs



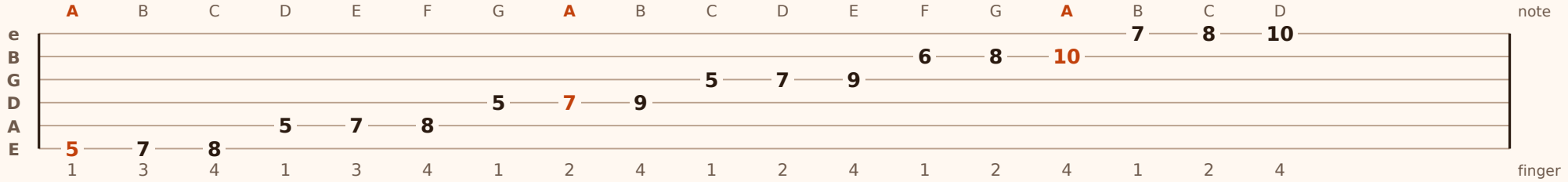
Octave reference

- **6th string, fret 5** — low A
- **4th string, fret 7** — A · 1 octave up
- **2nd string, fret 10** — A · 2 octaves up
- joins each A to the A an octave up

Notes in this scale

A	B	C	D	E	F	G
1	2	♭3	4	5	♭6	♭7

Play up (low to high)



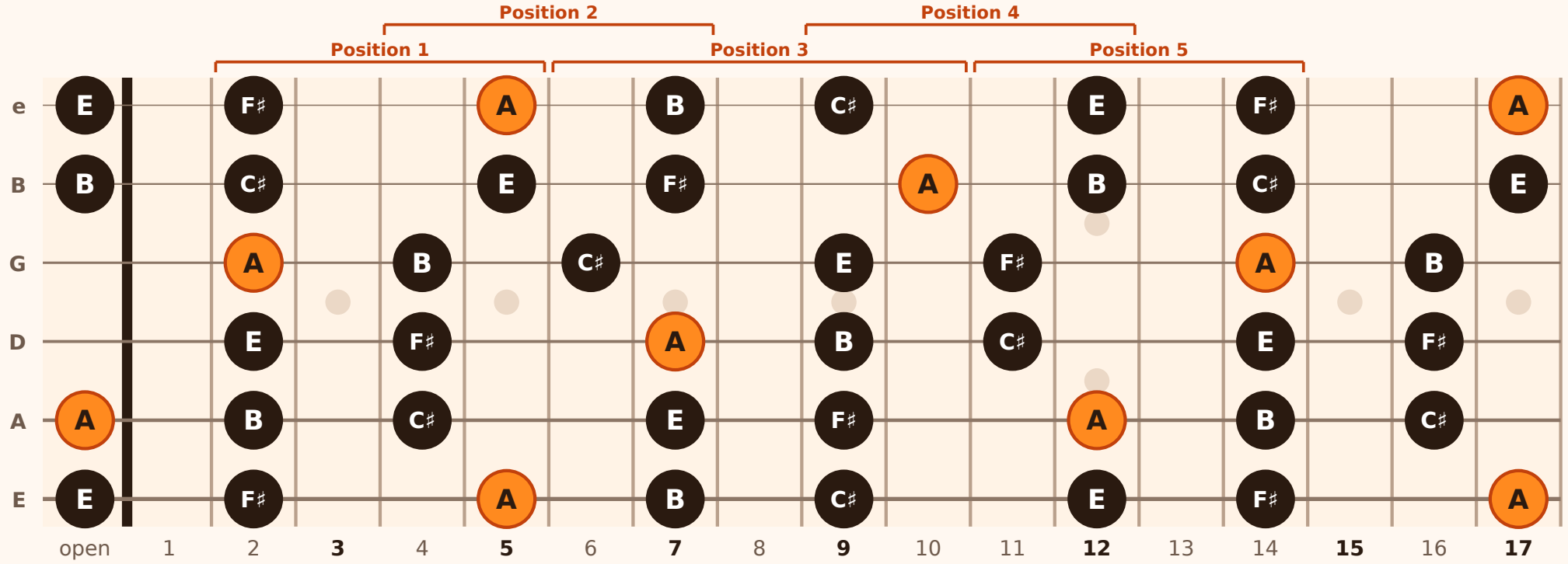
Play down (high to low)



Tip: Three notes on each string. Pick down-up-down evenly; this is the shape for fast runs.

A Major Pentatonic

Six ways to play it · Five notes, no wrong notes. Sweet and open: great for fills between singing.



The whole neck

Every dot above is a note of the scale. Orange dots are A, the home note. The five positions sit side by side and overlap, so you can move from one to the next. Way 6 joins them in one long shape.

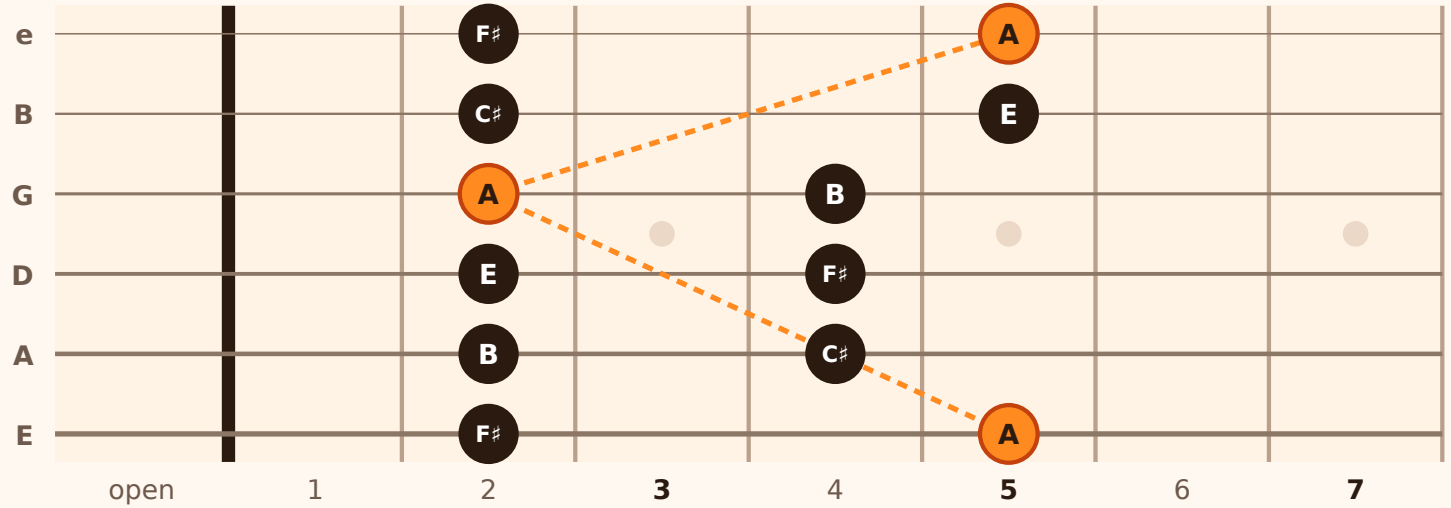
How to use these pages

1. Play over A major songs. Good for country, gospel and worship fills.
2. Learn one position a week. Play it up and down, slowly, saying the note names.
3. Find the orange A notes first: they are your map.
4. Then join two positions together on the neck.

Notes: A (1) B (2) C♯ (3) E (5) F♯ (6)

A Major Pentatonic — Way 1 · Position 1

Frets 2–5 · Put your 1st finger at fret 2



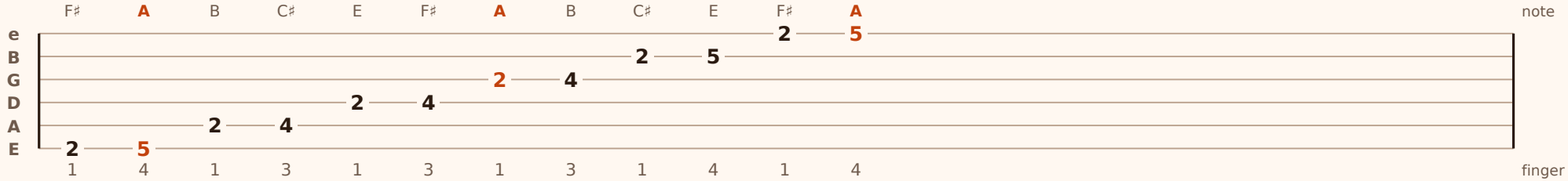
Octave reference

- **A** **6th string, fret 5** — low A
- **A** **3rd string, fret 2** — A · 1 octave up
- **A** **1st string, fret 5** — A · 2 octaves up
- joins each A to the A an octave up

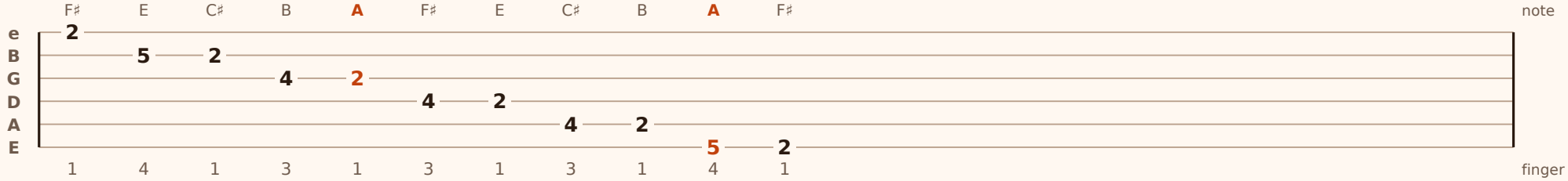
Notes in this scale

A	B	C♯	E	F♯
1	2	3	5	6

Play up (low to high)



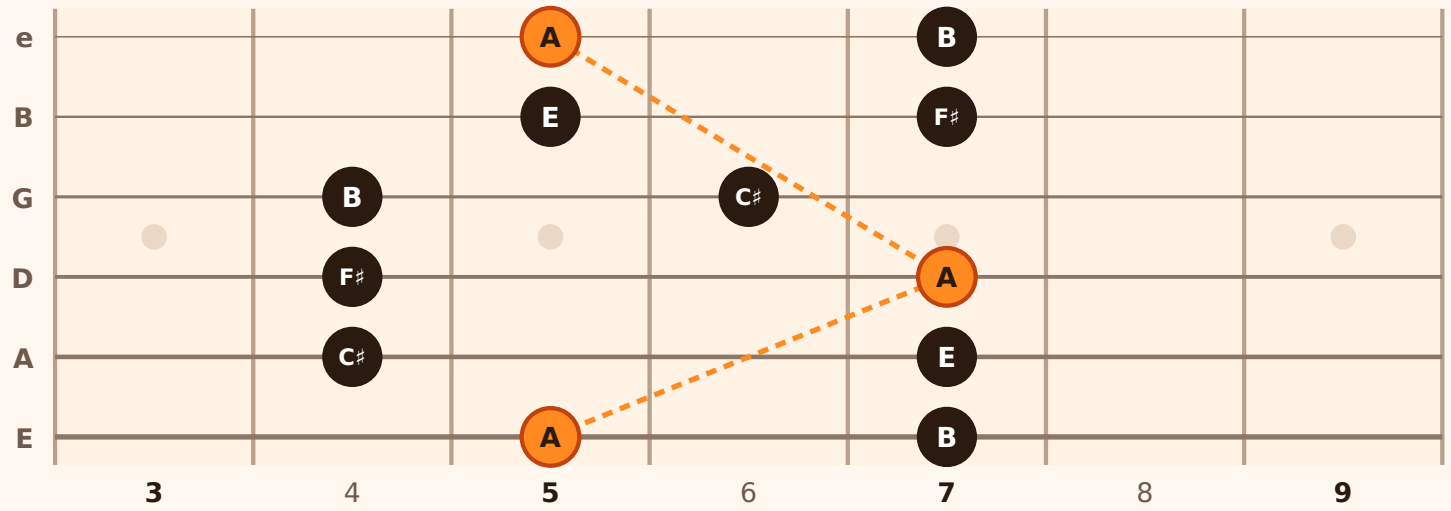
Play down (high to low)



Tip: Say the note names as you play. Start and finish on an orange A. Use a metronome at 60, then speed up.

A Major Pentatonic — Way 2 · Position 2

Frets 4–7 · Put your 1st finger at fret 4



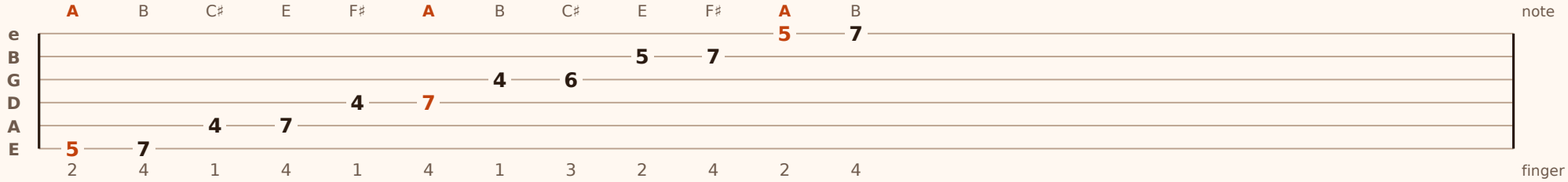
Octave reference

- **A** **6th string, fret 5** — low A
- **A** **4th string, fret 7** — A · 1 octave up
- **A** **1st string, fret 5** — A · 2 octaves up
- joins each A to the A an octave up

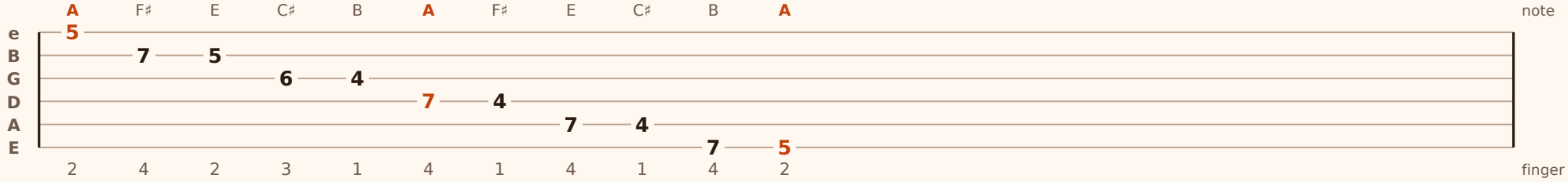
Notes in this scale

A	B	C♯	E	F♯
1	2	3	5	6

Play up (low to high)



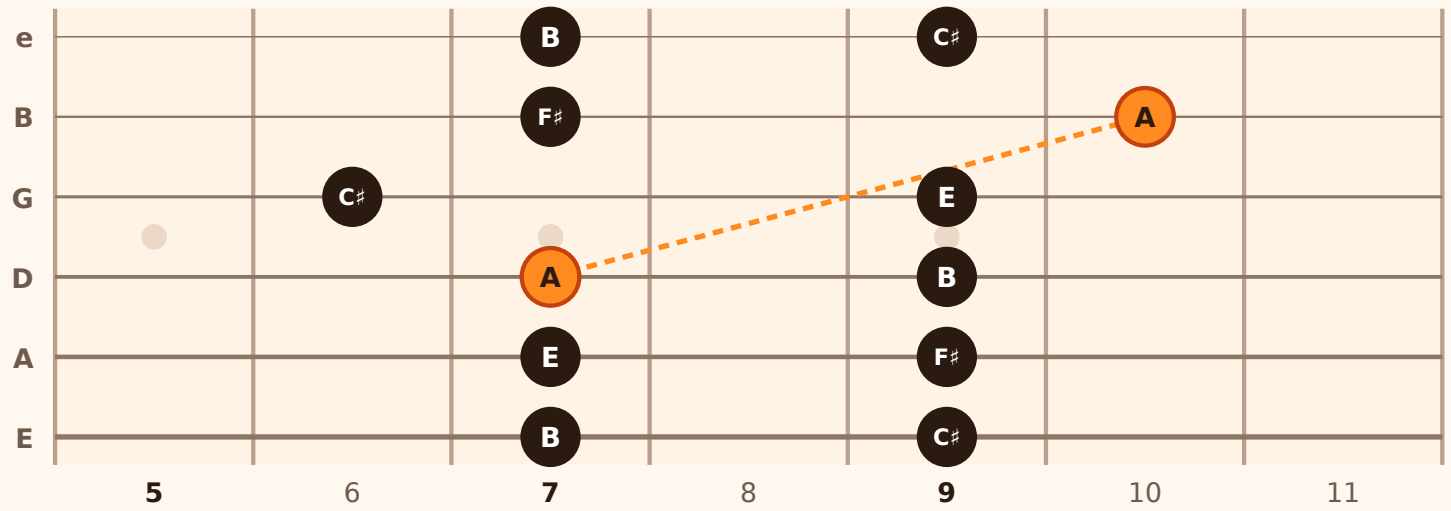
Play down (high to low)



Tip: Say the note names as you play. Start and finish on an orange A. Use a metronome at 60, then speed up.

A Major Pentatonic — Way 3 · Position 3

Frets 6–10 · Put your 1st finger at fret 7



Octave reference

A **4th string, fret 7**
A · 1 octave up

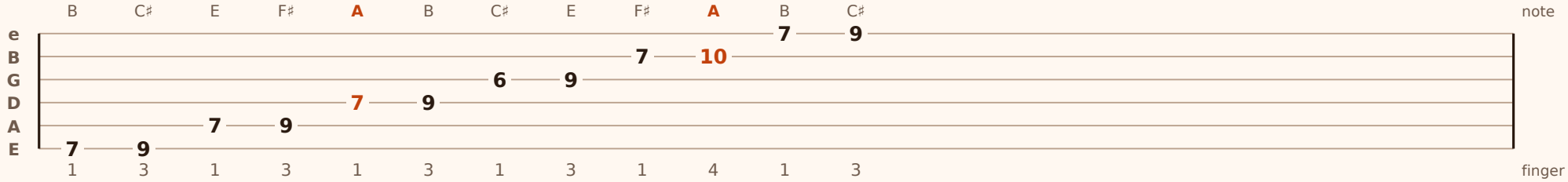
A **2nd string, fret 10**
A · 2 octaves up

joins each A to the A an octave up

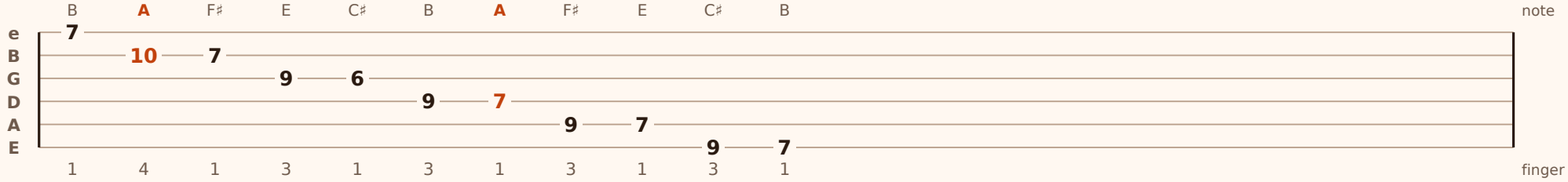
Notes in this scale

A	B	C♯	E	F♯
1	2	3	5	6

Play up (low to high)



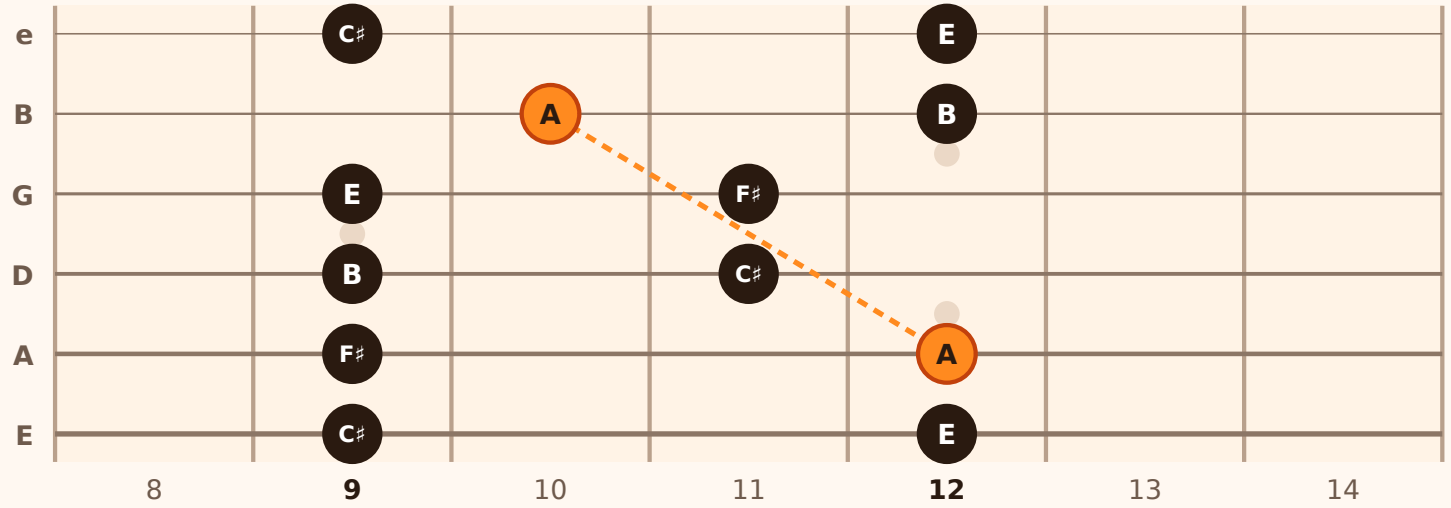
Play down (high to low)



Tip: Say the note names as you play. Start and finish on an orange A. Use a metronome at 60, then speed up.

A Major Pentatonic — Way 4 · Position 4

Frets 9–12 · Put your 1st finger at fret 9



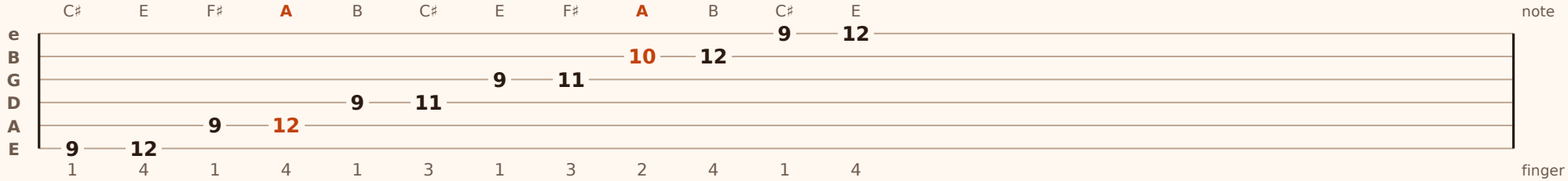
Octave reference

- **A** **5th string, fret 12**
  A · 1 octave up
- **A** **2nd string, fret 10**
  A · 2 octaves up
- joins each A to the A an octave up

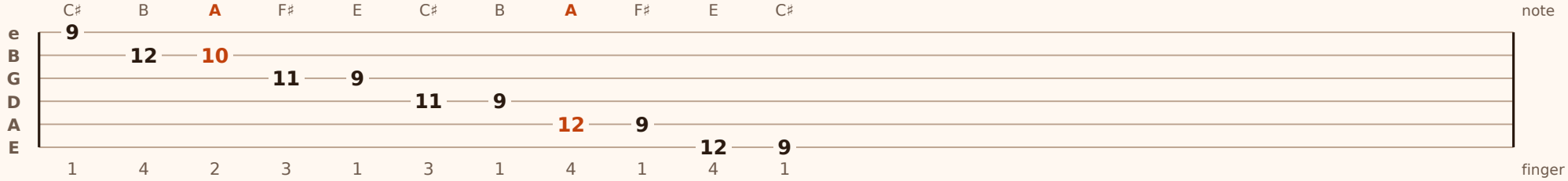
Notes in this scale

A	B	C♯	E	F♯
1	2	3	5	6

Play up (low to high)



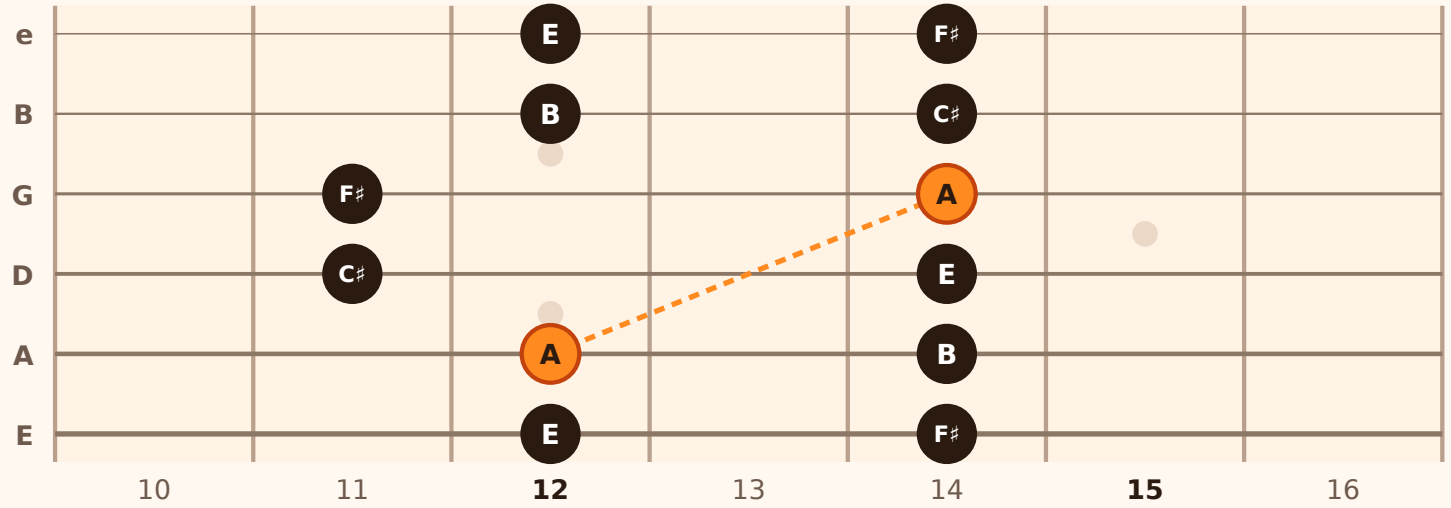
Play down (high to low)



Tip: Say the note names as you play. Start and finish on an orange A. Use a metronome at 60, then speed up.

A Major Pentatonic — Way 5 · Position 5

Frets 11–14 · Put your 1st finger at fret 11



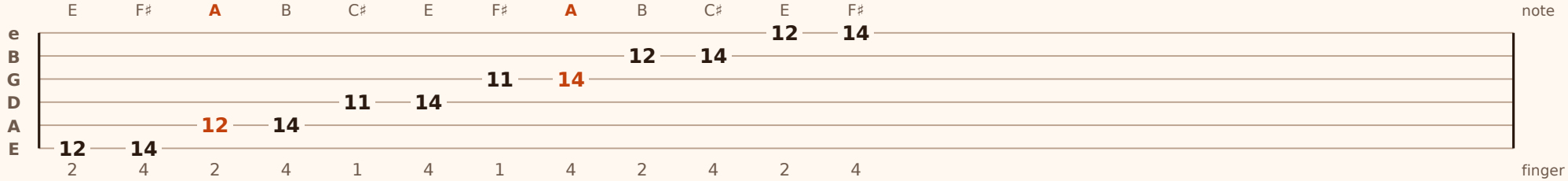
Octave reference

- **A** **5th string, fret 12**
  A · 1 octave up
- **A** **3rd string, fret 14**
  A · 2 octaves up
- joins each A to the A an octave up

Notes in this scale

A	B	C♯	E	F♯
1	2	3	5	6

Play up (low to high)



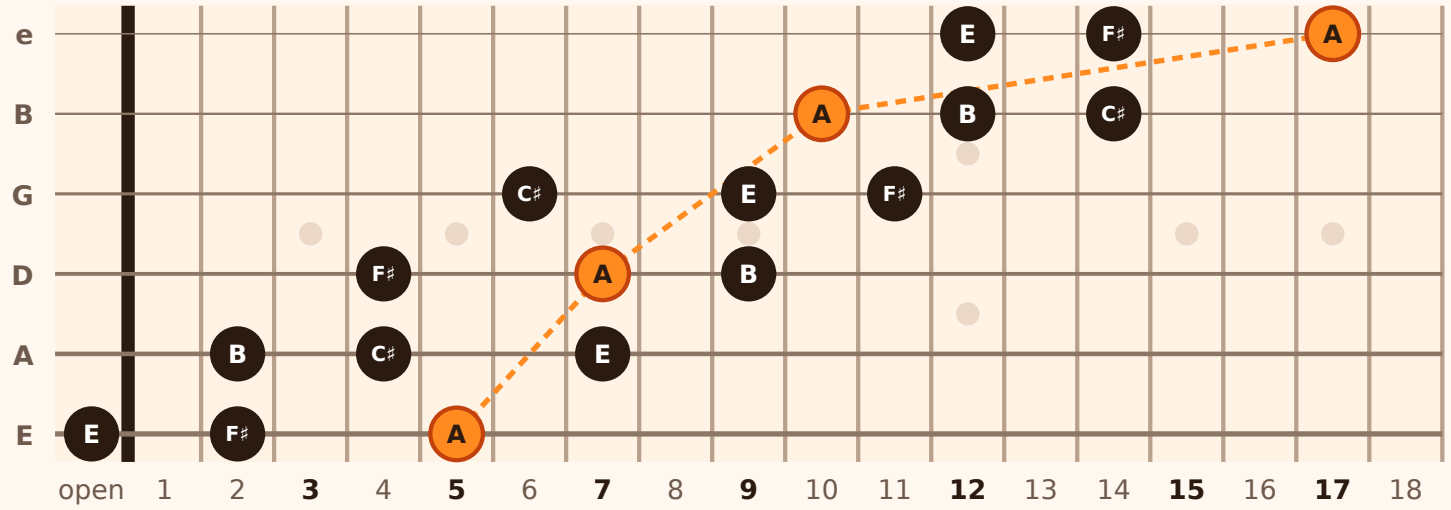
Play down (high to low)



Tip: Say the note names as you play. Start and finish on an orange A. Use a metronome at 60, then speed up.

A Major Pentatonic — Way 6 · Across the neck (diagonal)

Frets 0–17 · Climb the whole neck: slide your hand up as you change strings



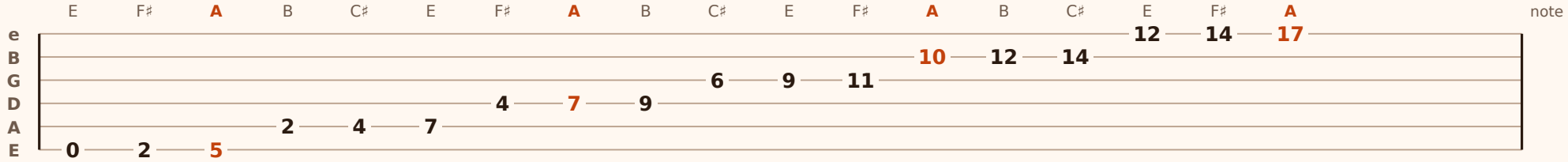
Octave reference

- **A** **6th string, fret 5** — low A
- **A** **4th string, fret 7** — A · 1 octave up
- **A** **2nd string, fret 10** — A · 2 octaves up
- **A** **1st string, fret 17** — A · 3 octaves up
- joins each A to the A an octave up

Notes in this scale

A	B	C♯	E	F♯
1	2	3	5	6

Play up (low to high)



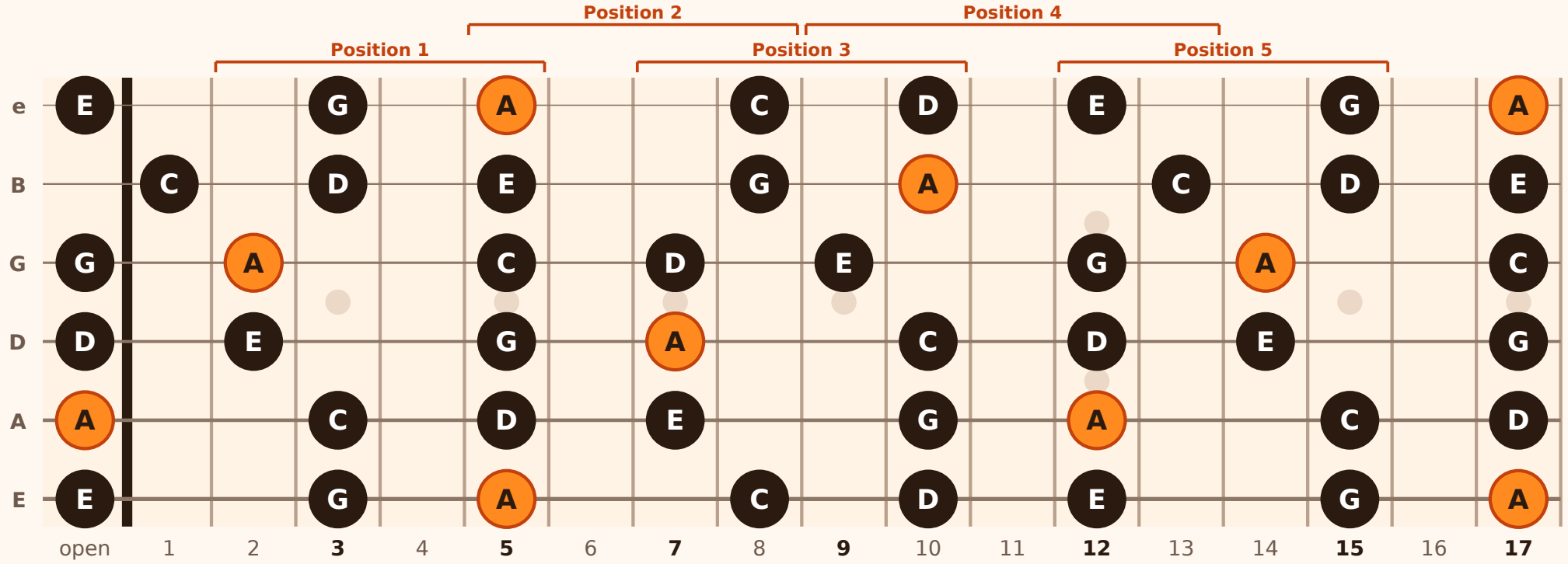
Play down (high to low)



Tip: Shift up with your 1st or 3rd finger when you move to the next string. Great for solos across the neck.

A Minor Pentatonic

Six ways to play it · The most-used scale for guitar solos: rock, blues and pop.



The whole neck

Every dot above is a note of the scale. Orange dots are A, the home note. The five positions sit side by side and overlap, so you can move from one to the next. Way 6 joins them in one long shape.

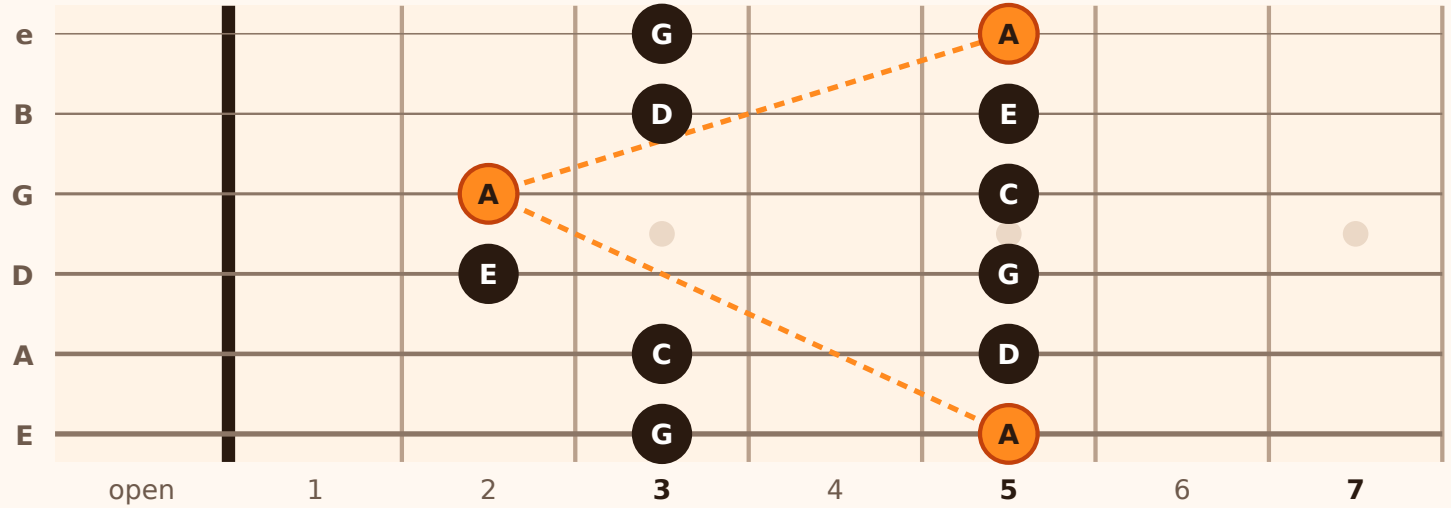
How to use these pages

1. Play over A minor songs, or an A blues / rock groove.
2. Learn one position a week. Play it up and down, slowly, saying the note names.
3. Find the orange A notes first: they are your map.
4. Then join two positions together on the neck.

Notes: A (1) C (♭3) D (4) E (5) G (♭7)

A Minor Pentatonic — Way 1 · Position 1

Frets 2–5 · Put your 1st finger at fret 2



Octave reference

- **A 6th string, fret 5** — low A
- **A 3rd string, fret 2** — A · 1 octave up
- **A 1st string, fret 5** — A · 2 octaves up
- joins each A to the A an octave up

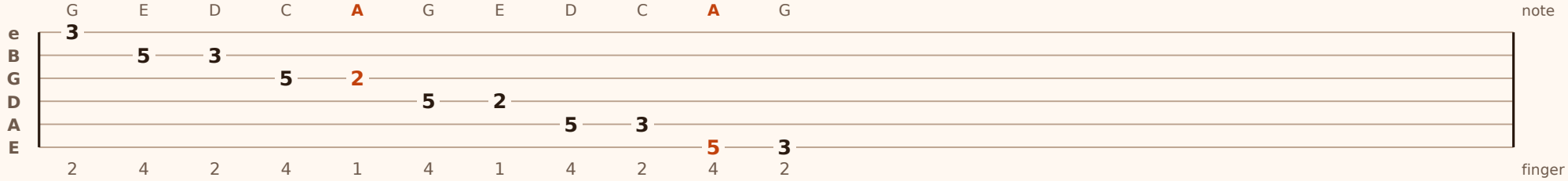
Notes in this scale

A	C	D	E	G
1	♭3	4	5	♭7

Play up (low to high)



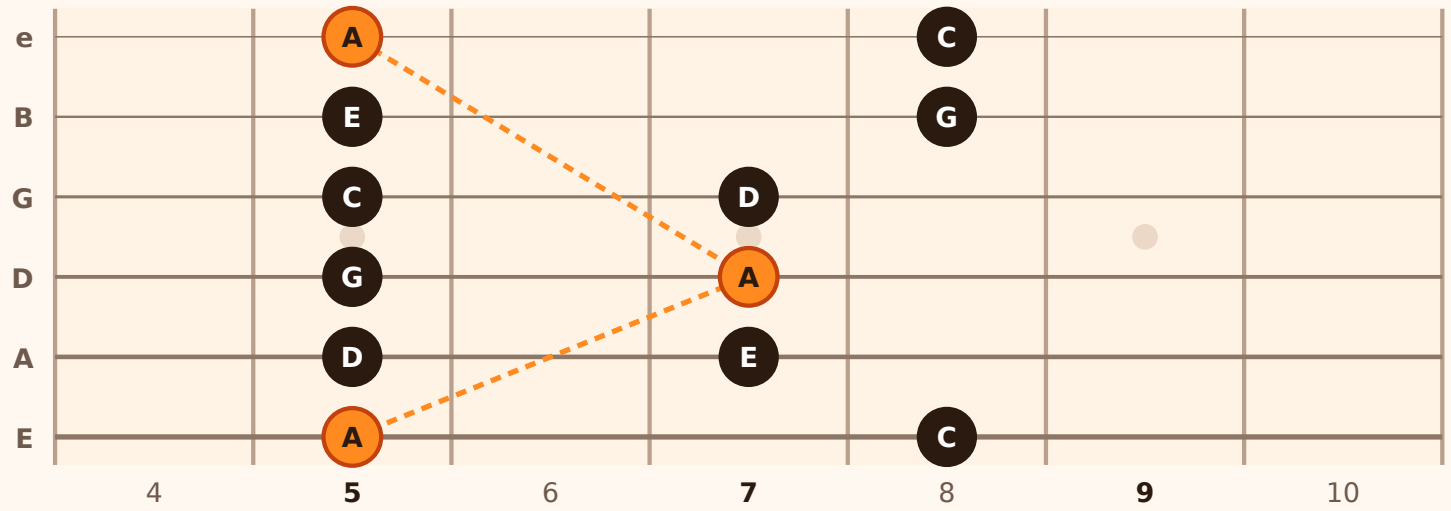
Play down (high to low)



Tip: Say the note names as you play. Start and finish on an orange A. Use a metronome at 60, then speed up.

A Minor Pentatonic — Way 2 · Position 2

Frets 5–8 · Put your 1st finger at fret 5



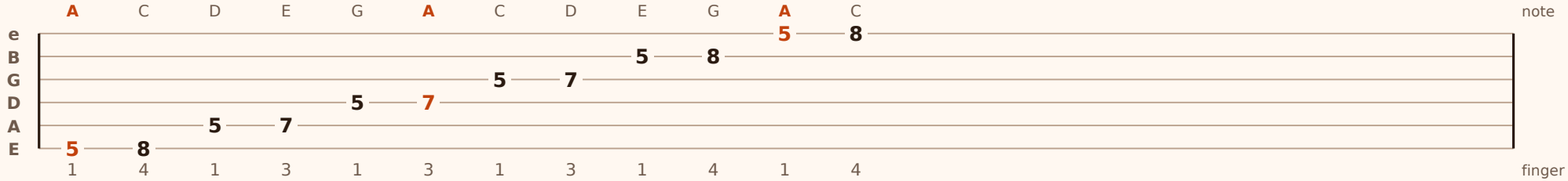
Octave reference

- **A 6th string, fret 5** — low A
- **A 4th string, fret 7** — A · 1 octave up
- **A 1st string, fret 5** — A · 2 octaves up
- joins each A to the A an octave up

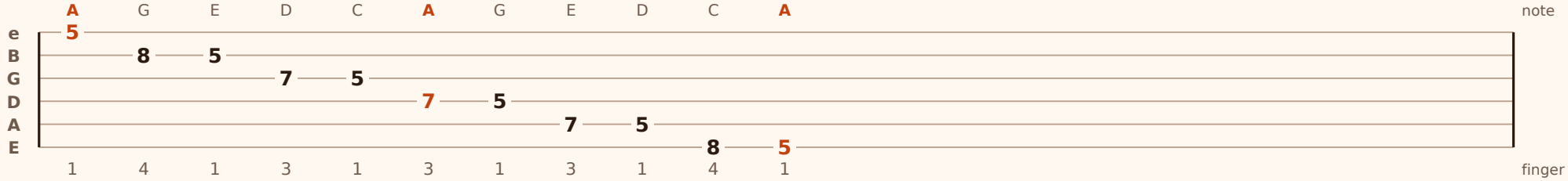
Notes in this scale

A	C	D	E	G
1	♭3	4	5	♭7

Play up (low to high)



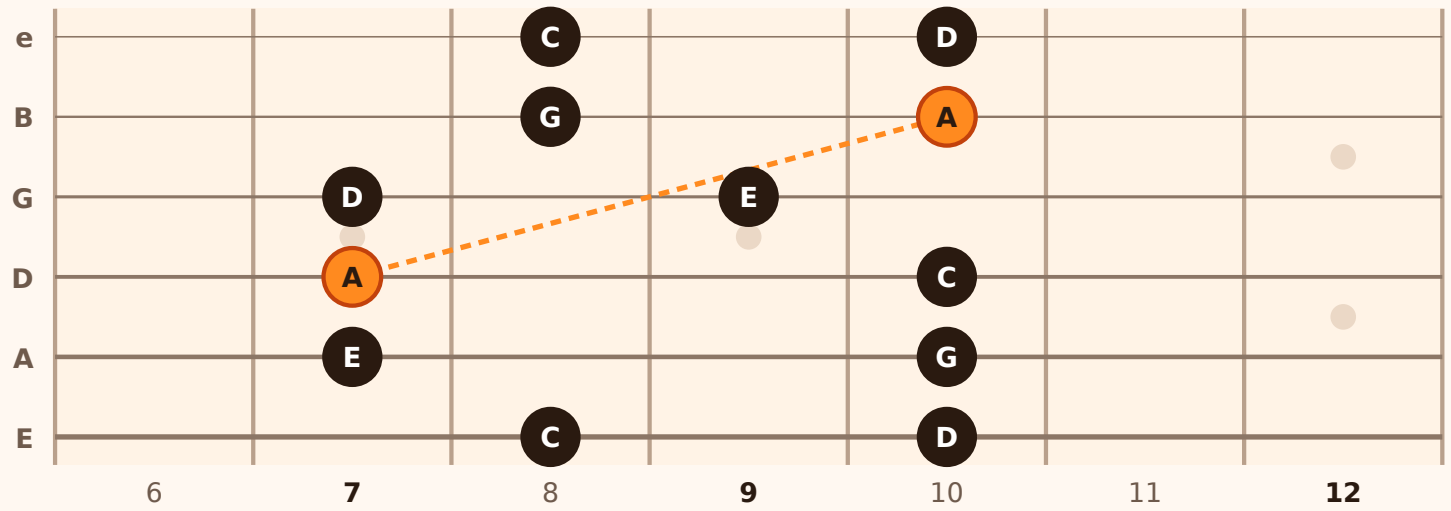
Play down (high to low)



Tip: Say the note names as you play. Start and finish on an orange A. Use a metronome at 60, then speed up.

A Minor Pentatonic — Way 3 · Position 3

Frets 7–10 · Put your 1st finger at fret 7



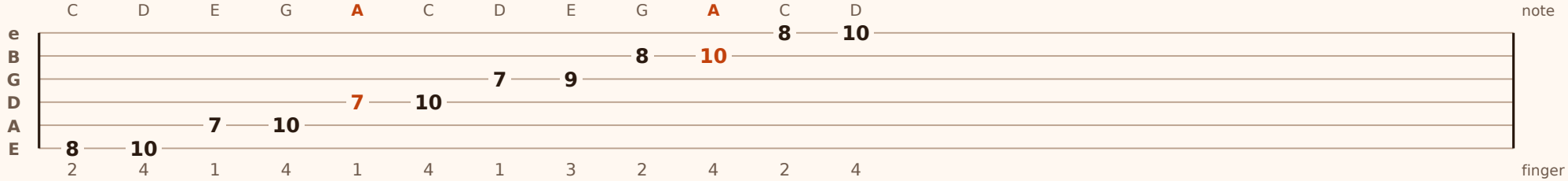
Octave reference

- **A 4th string, fret 7**
  A · 1 octave up
- **A 2nd string, fret 10**
  A · 2 octaves up
- joins each A to the A an octave up

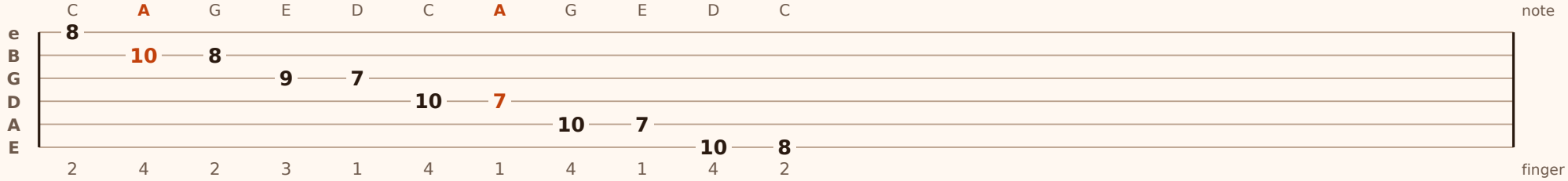
Notes in this scale

A	C	D	E	G
1	♭3	4	5	♭7

Play up (low to high)



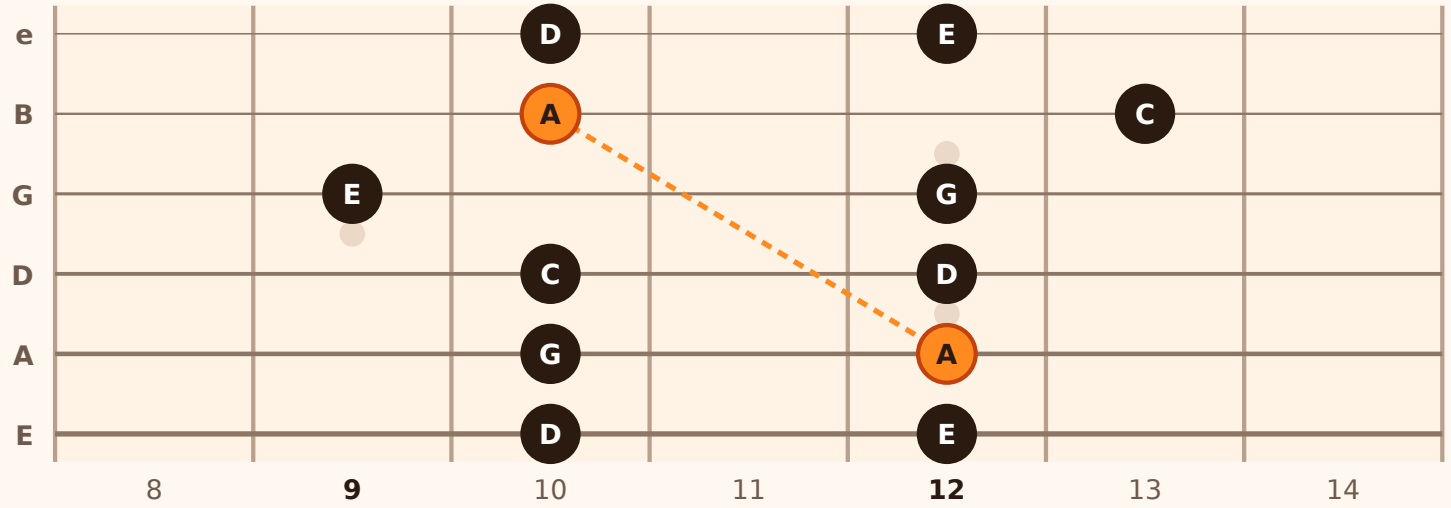
Play down (high to low)



Tip: Say the note names as you play. Start and finish on an orange A. Use a metronome at 60, then speed up.

A Minor Pentatonic — Way 4 · Position 4

Frets 9–13 · Put your 1st finger at fret 10



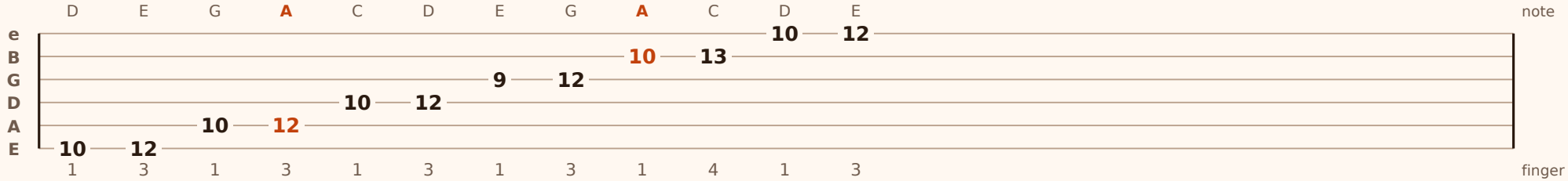
Octave reference

- **A** **5th string, fret 12**
  A · 1 octave up
- **A** **2nd string, fret 10**
  A · 2 octaves up
- joins each A to the A an octave up

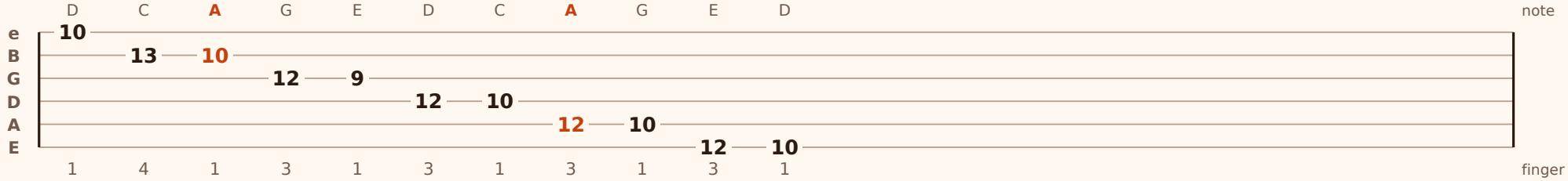
Notes in this scale

A	C	D	E	G
1	♭3	4	5	♭7

Play up (low to high)



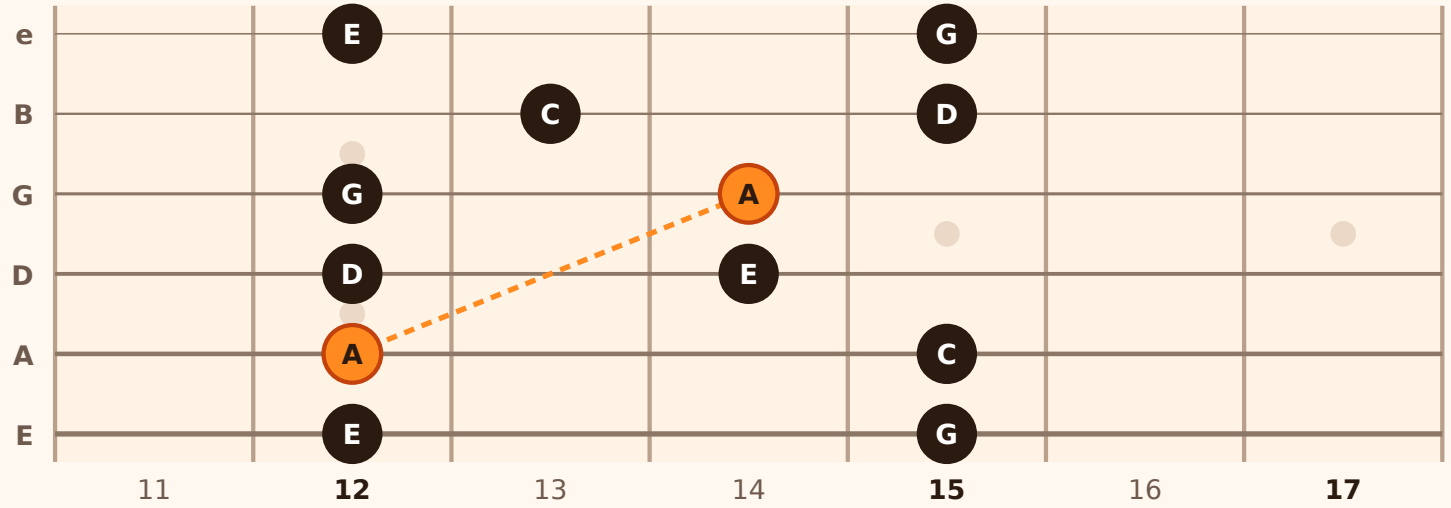
Play down (high to low)



Tip: Say the note names as you play. Start and finish on an orange A. Use a metronome at 60, then speed up.

A Minor Pentatonic — Way 5 · Position 5

Frets 12–15 · Put your 1st finger at fret 12



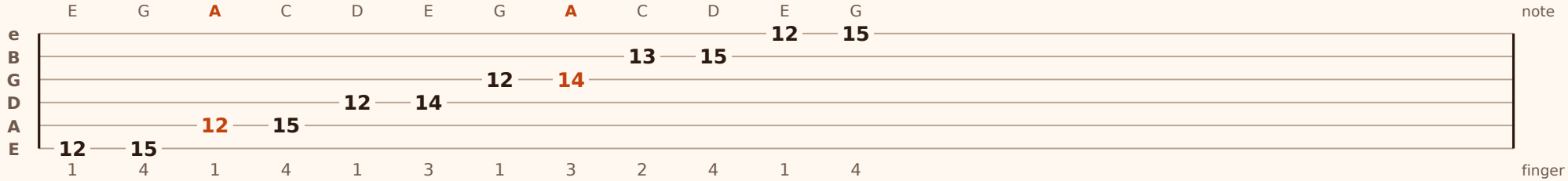
Octave reference

- **A** **5th string, fret 12**
  A · 1 octave up
- **A** **3rd string, fret 14**
  A · 2 octaves up
- joins each A to the A an octave up

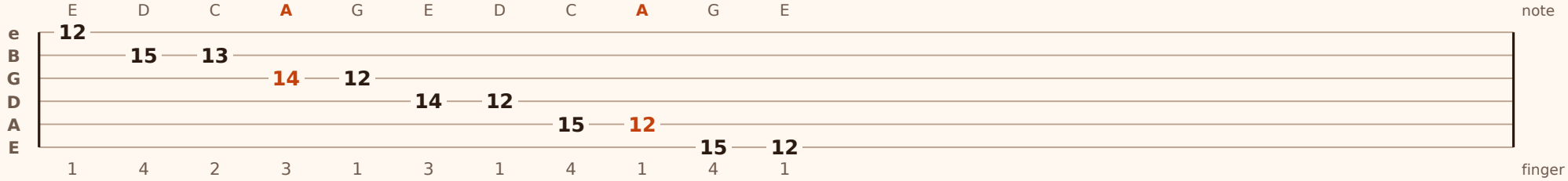
Notes in this scale

A	C	D	E	G
1	♭3	4	5	♭7

Play up (low to high)



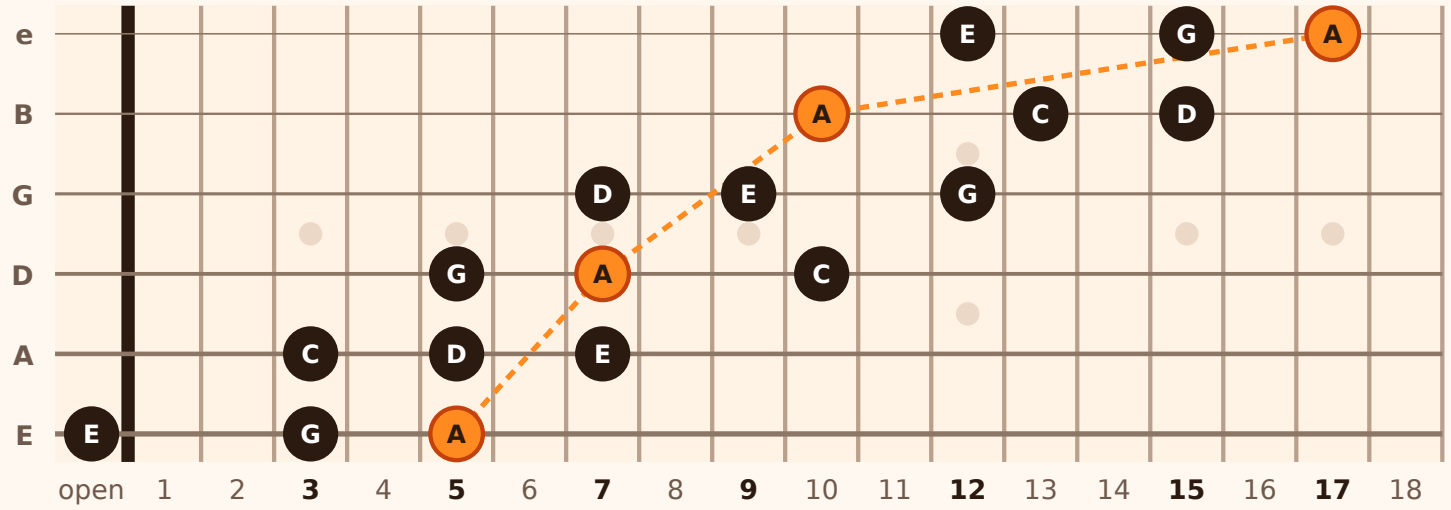
Play down (high to low)



Tip: Say the note names as you play. Start and finish on an orange A. Use a metronome at 60, then speed up.

A Minor Pentatonic — Way 6 · Across the neck (diagonal)

Frets 0–17 · Climb the whole neck: slide your hand up as you change strings



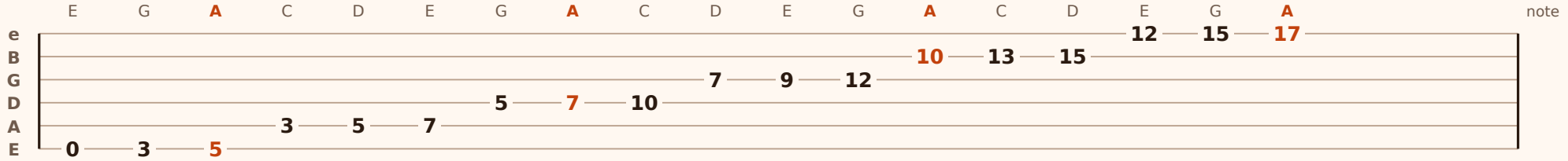
Octave reference

- **6th string, fret 5** — low A
- **4th string, fret 7** — A · 1 octave up
- **2nd string, fret 10** — A · 2 octaves up
- **1st string, fret 17** — A · 3 octaves up
- joins each A to the A an octave up

Notes in this scale

A	C	D	E	G
1	♭3	4	5	♭7

Play up (low to high)



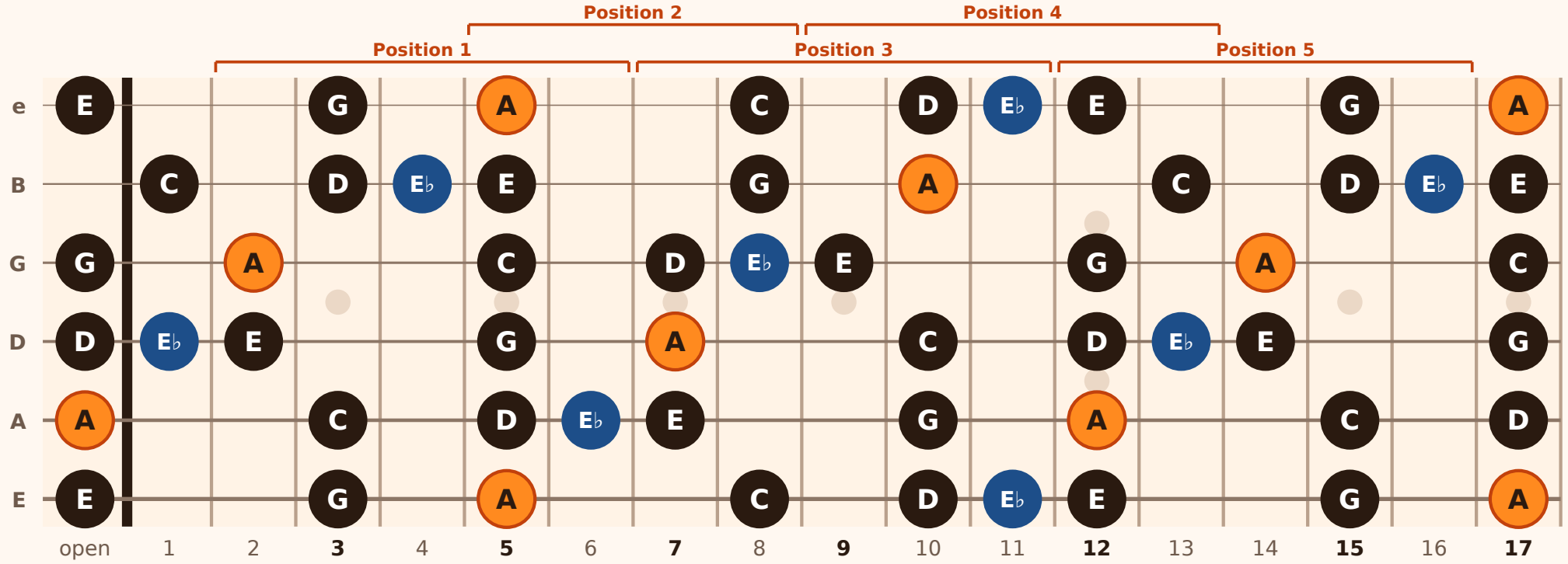
Play down (high to low)



Tip: Shift up with your 1st or 3rd finger when you move to the next string. Great for solos across the neck.

A Blues Scale

Six ways to play it · The minor pentatonic plus one “blue note” (E♭). Gives the crying blues sound.



The whole neck

Every dot above is a note of the scale. Orange dots are A, the home note. The five positions sit side by side and overlap, so you can move from one to the next. Way 6 joins them in one long shape.

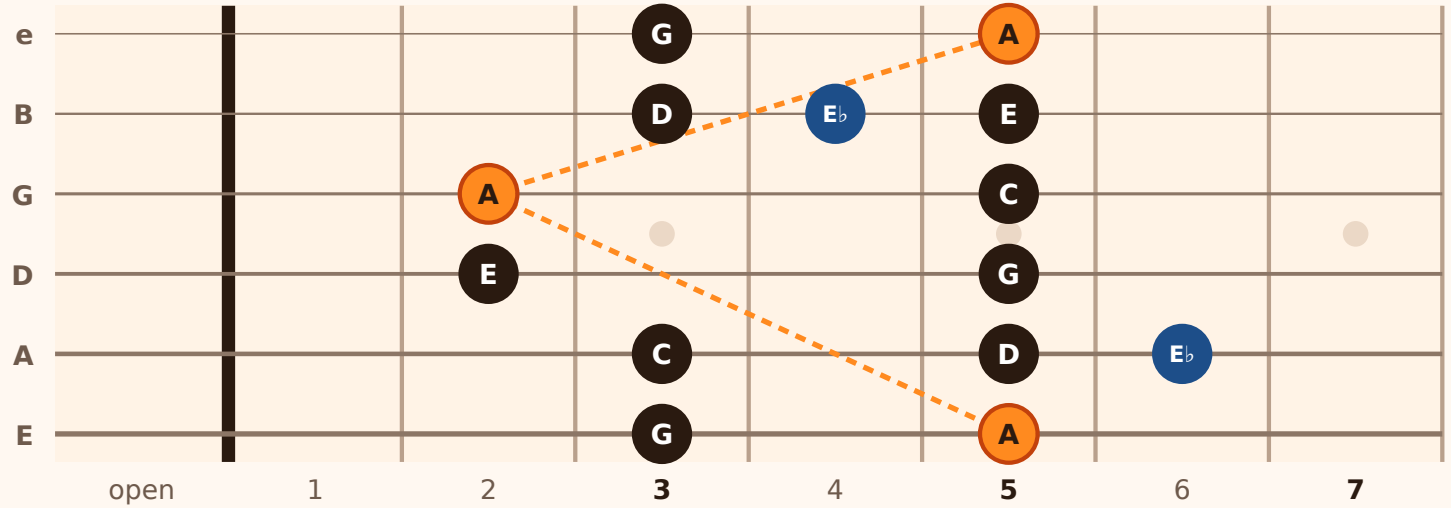
How to use these pages

1. Play over a 12-bar blues in A. Slide or bend into the blue note.
2. Learn one position a week. Play it up and down, slowly, saying the note names.
3. Find the orange A notes first: they are your map.
4. Then join two positions together on the neck.

Notes: A (1) C (♭3) D (4) E♭ (♭5) E (5) G (♭7)

A Blues Scale — Way 1 · Position 1

Frets 2–6 · Put your 1st finger at fret 2



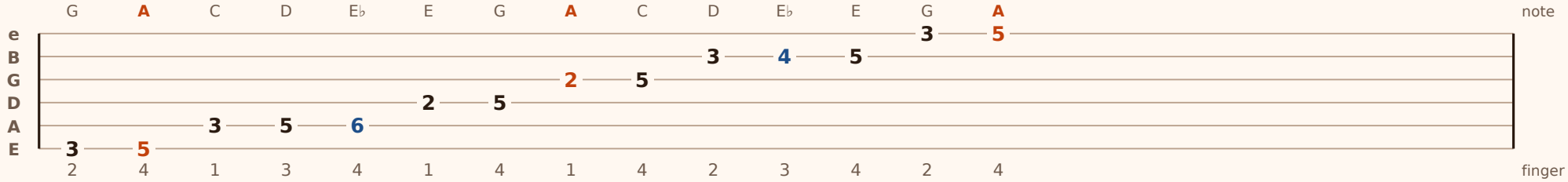
Octave reference

- **6th string, fret 5** — low A
- **3rd string, fret 2** — A · 1 octave up
- **1st string, fret 5** — A · 2 octaves up
- joins each A to the A an octave up

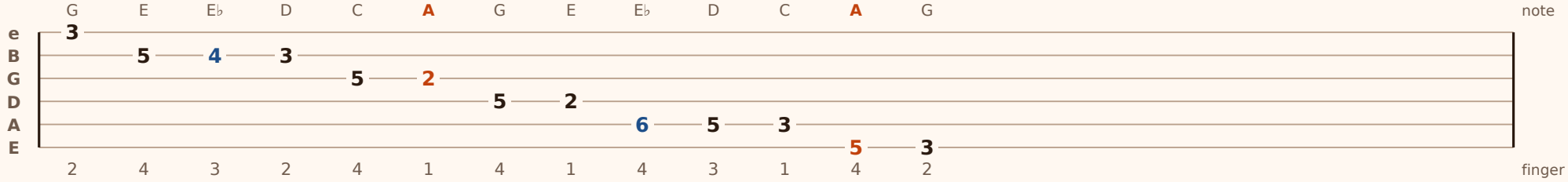
Notes in this scale

A	C	D	E♭	E	G
1	♭3	4	♭5	5	♭7

Play up (low to high)



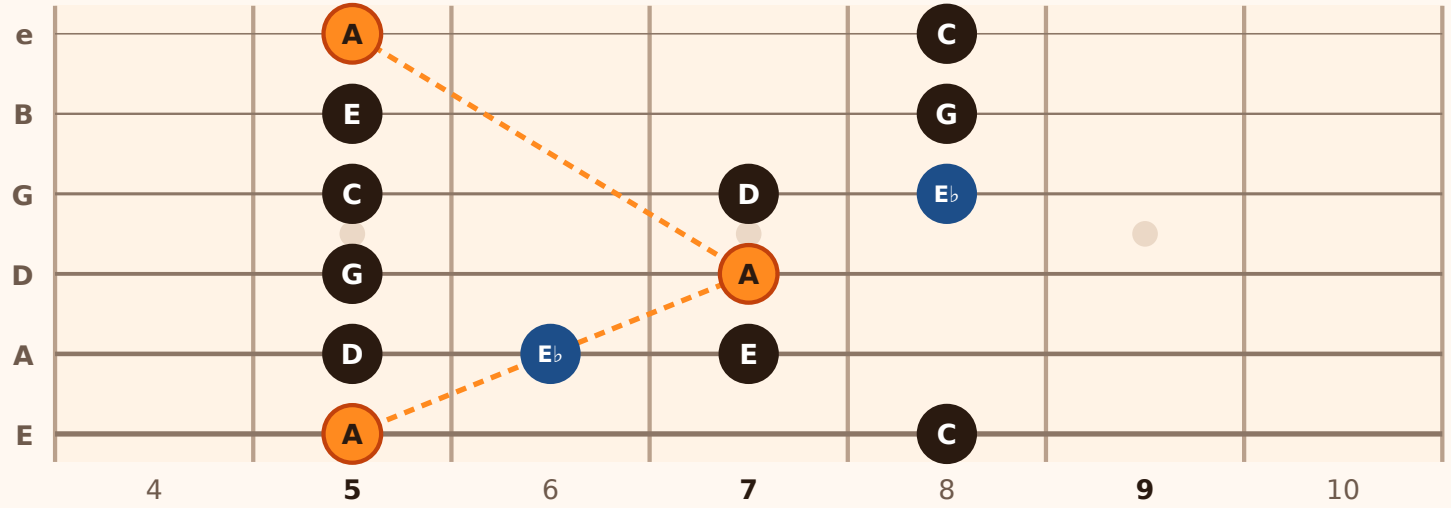
Play down (high to low)



Tip: Say the note names as you play. Start and finish on an orange A. Use a metronome at 60, then speed up.

A Blues Scale — Way 2 · Position 2

Frets 5–8 · Put your 1st finger at fret 5



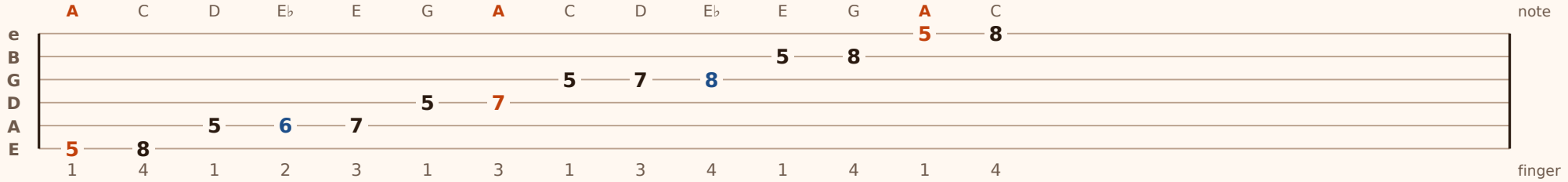
Octave reference

- **A** **6th string, fret 5** — low A
- **A** **4th string, fret 7** — A · 1 octave up
- **A** **1st string, fret 5** — A · 2 octaves up
- joins each A to the A an octave up

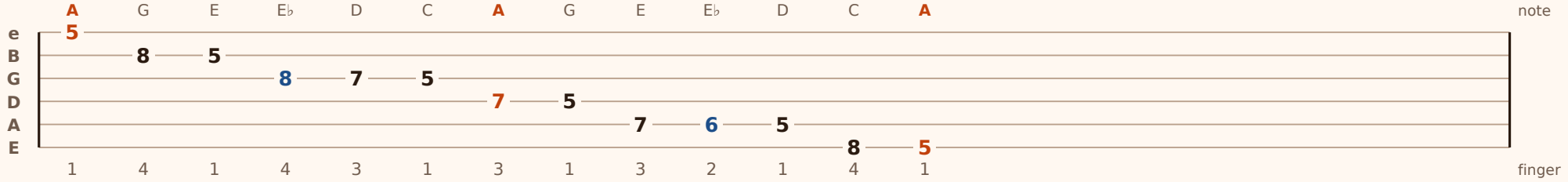
Notes in this scale

A	C	D	E♭	E	G
1	♭3	4	♭5	5	♭7

Play up (low to high)



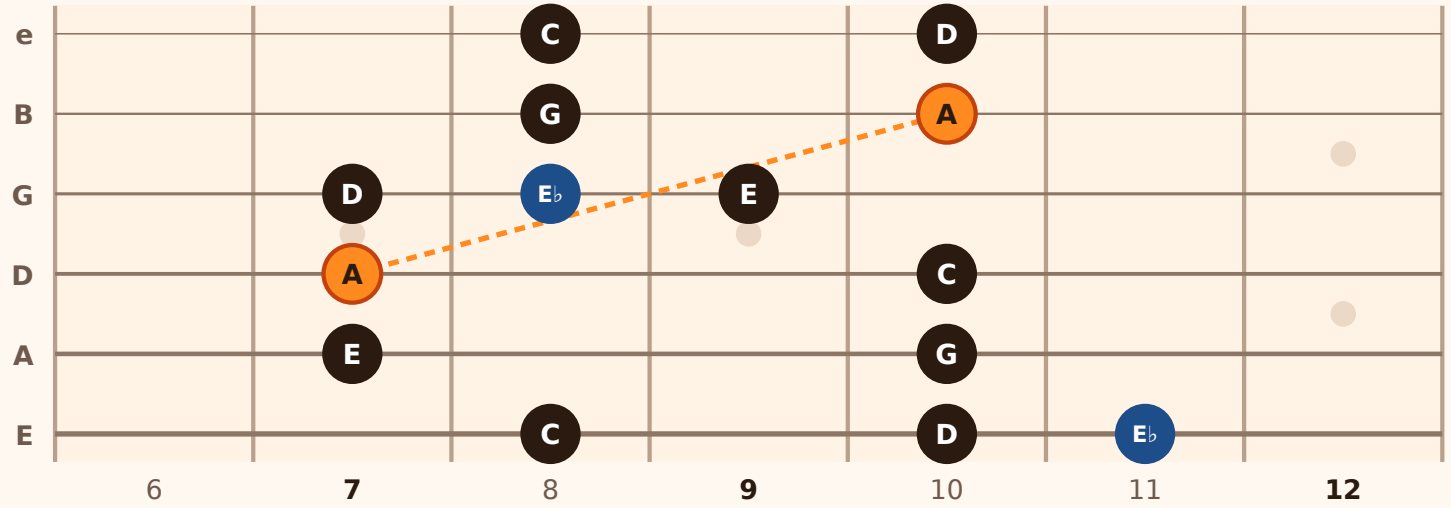
Play down (high to low)



Tip: Say the note names as you play. Start and finish on an orange A. Use a metronome at 60, then speed up.

A Blues Scale — Way 3 · Position 3

Frets 7–11 · Put your 1st finger at fret 7



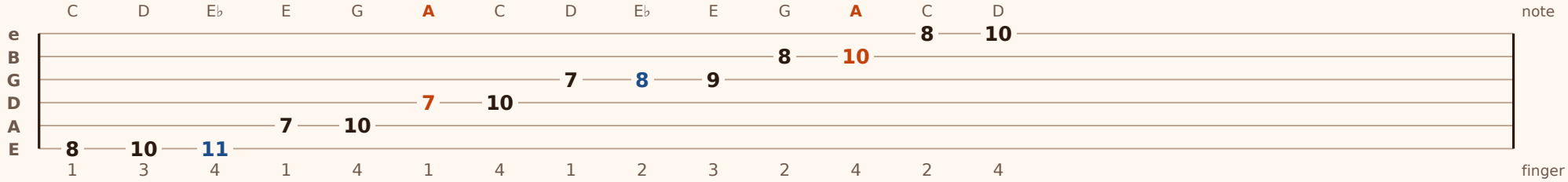
Octave reference

- **A** **4th string, fret 7**
  A · 1 octave up
- **A** **2nd string, fret 10**
  A · 2 octaves up
- joins each A to the A an octave up

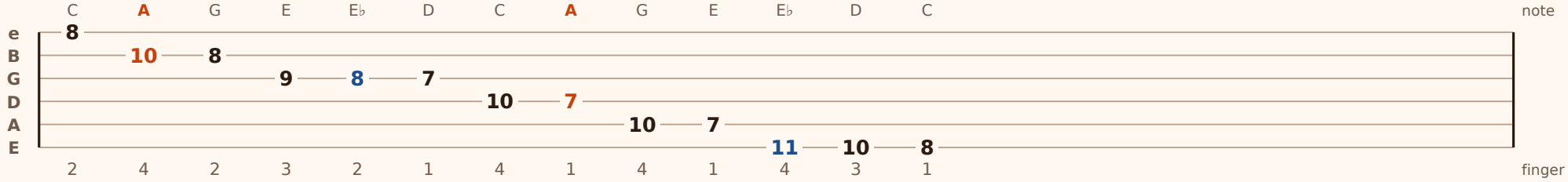
Notes in this scale

A	C	D	E♭	E	G
1	♭3	4	♭5	5	♭7

Play up (low to high)



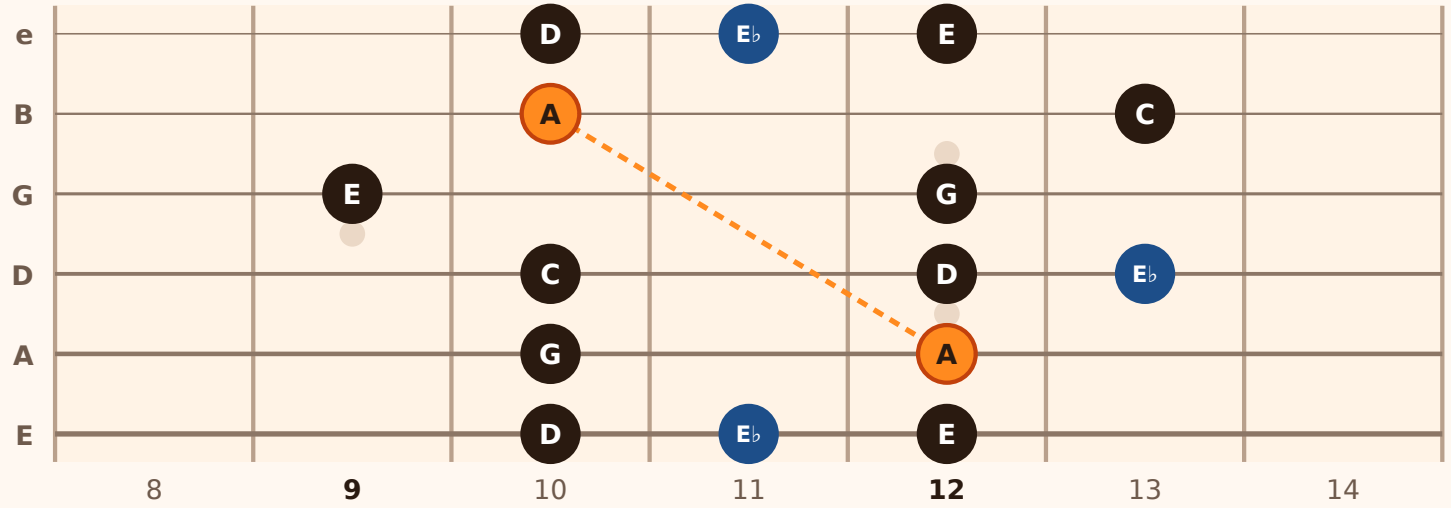
Play down (high to low)



Tip: Say the note names as you play. Start and finish on an orange A. Use a metronome at 60, then speed up.

A Blues Scale — Way 4 · Position 4

Frets 9–13 · Put your 1st finger at fret 10



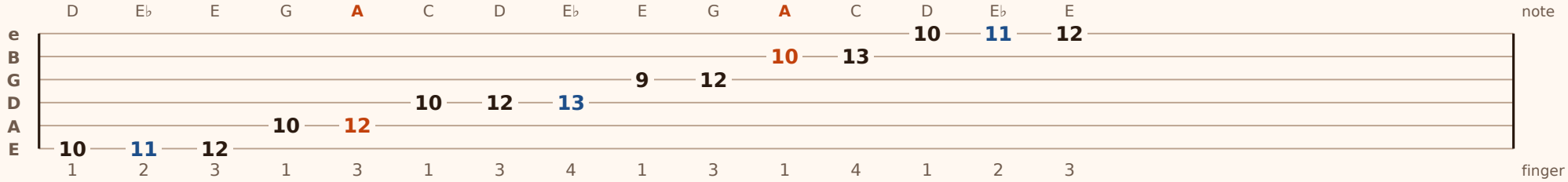
Octave reference

- **A** **5th string, fret 12**
  A · 1 octave up
- **A** **2nd string, fret 10**
  A · 2 octaves up
- joins each A to the A an octave up

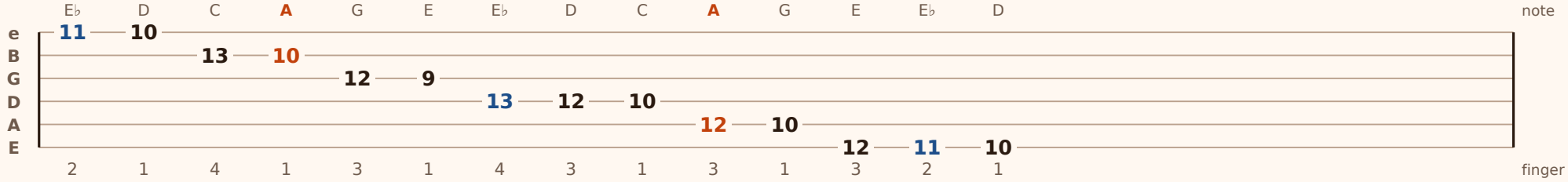
Notes in this scale

A	C	D	E♭	E	G
1	♭3	4	♭5	5	♭7

Play up (low to high)



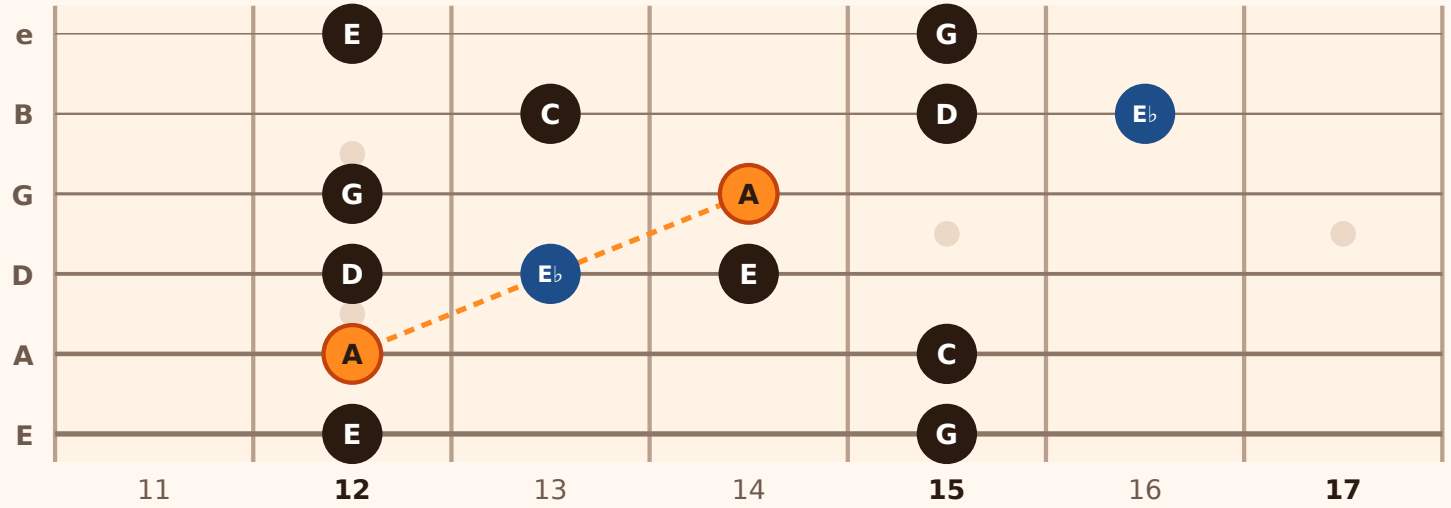
Play down (high to low)



Tip: Say the note names as you play. Start and finish on an orange A. Use a metronome at 60, then speed up.

A Blues Scale — Way 5 · Position 5

Frets 12–16 · Put your 1st finger at fret 12



Octave reference

A **5th string, fret 12**
A · 1 octave up

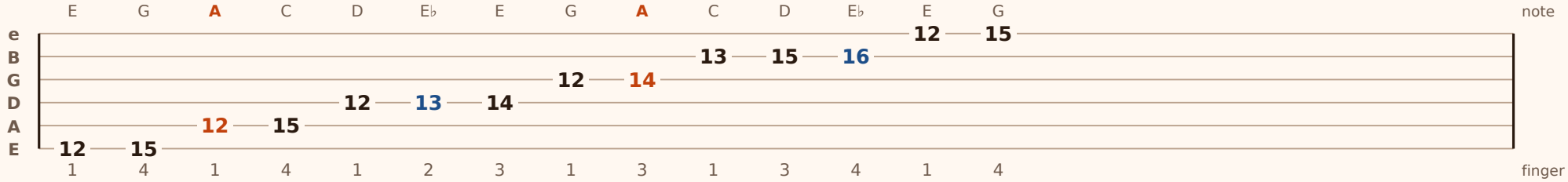
A **3rd string, fret 14**
A · 2 octaves up

joins each A to the A an octave up

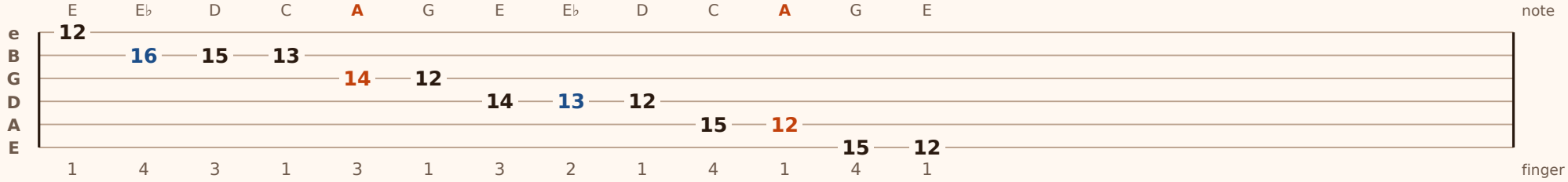
Notes in this scale

A	C	D	E♭	E	G
1	♭3	4	♭5	5	♭7

Play up (low to high)



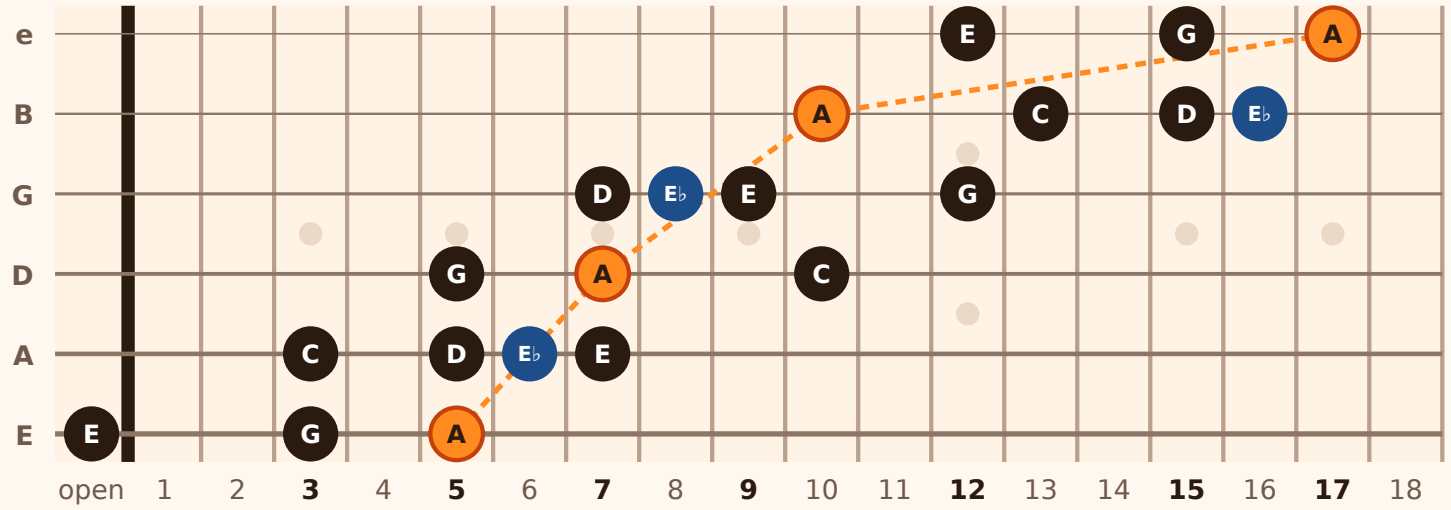
Play down (high to low)



Tip: Say the note names as you play. Start and finish on an orange A. Use a metronome at 60, then speed up.

A Blues Scale — Way 6 · Across the neck (diagonal)

Frets 0–17 · Climb the whole neck: slide your hand up as you change strings



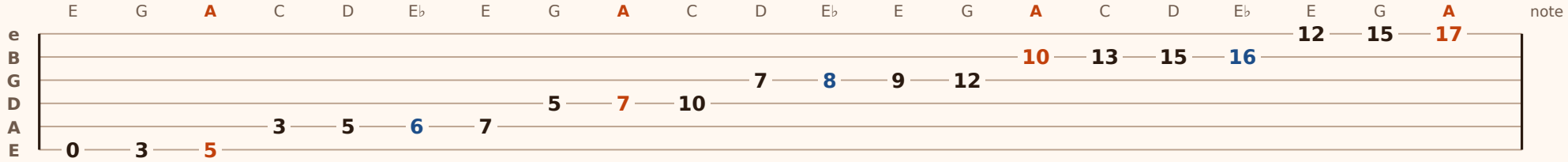
Octave reference

- **A** **6th string, fret 5** — low A
- **A** **4th string, fret 7** — A · 1 octave up
- **A** **2nd string, fret 10** — A · 2 octaves up
- **A** **1st string, fret 17** — A · 3 octaves up
- joins each A to the A an octave up

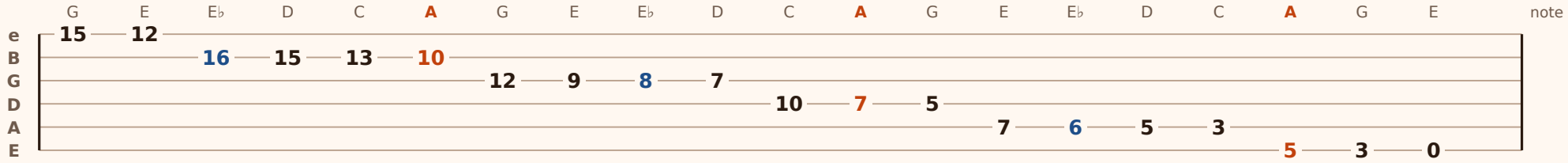
Notes in this scale

A	C	D	E♭	E	G
1	♭3	4	♭5	5	♭7

Play up (low to high)



Play down (high to low)



Tip: Shift up with your 1st or 3rd finger when you move to the next string. Great for solos across the neck.

Play in any key

Every shape in this book moves. Slide the whole shape so the orange dot lands on your new home note.

Key	Home note on 6th string	Move every number by
E	open (or fret 12)	-5 frets
F	fret 1	-4 frets
F♯ / G♭	fret 2	-3 frets
G	fret 3	-2 frets
G♯ / A♭	fret 4	-1 frets
A	fret 5	same as the book
A♯ / B♭	fret 6	+1 frets
B	fret 7	+2 frets
C	fret 8	+3 frets
C♯ / D♭	fret 9	+4 frets
D	fret 10	+5 frets
D♯ / E♭	fret 11	+6 frets

Example: G major

G is 2 frets lower than A. Take any A major page and play every fret number 2 lower. Position 2 (frets 4–7) becomes frets 2–5.

Minor key? Same rule.

For E minor, E is 5 frets lower than A (or 7 frets higher). Move the A minor shapes.

Remember

If a number goes below 0, add 12. If it goes above 17, take away 12.